

She cheated...
He enjoyed it

CHEAT CODES.

So why did
he erase her?

BOOK ONE

"AN EROTIC
TECHNO-THRILLER
LIKE NOTHING
YOU'VE EVER READ"

Delores Swallows
leading hotwife author

PAUL
GARLAND

Cheat Codes: A Hotpast Erotica

From The Elysium Files

Paul Garland



Cerulean Publishing

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Chapter One

The self-driving cab ride home from O'Malley's was a blur of Harry's drunken philosophizing and my failed attempts to keep a straight face. My best friend had it bad for Beth—three months of dating her, and he was already picking out theoretical children's names.

"All I'm saying," he slurred, poking a finger at me, "Is that Beth Junior has a ring to it."

I forced a laugh, pushing away the memory of Beth's gorgeous, slim, naked body writhing beneath me just a few months ago, right before she and Harry got together. That one drunken night we'd both immediately agreed to forget. The way I'd rammed my cock into her soft, shaven pussy. The way she'd begged me not to stop, her nails raking my back... Jesus. Now, here I was, listening to my best friend plan their future together. The guilt twisted in my stomach, but we'd made a pact—Harry could never know. It would destroy him.

You're an embarrassment," I managed to chuckle, watching him fumble with his phone to pay the cab fare. "And she spent the whole night telling you she hates kids."

"Details." He waved dismissively. "Minor details."

The cab's doors slid open onto 47th Street. September in Manhattan was all warm subway gusts and the constant thrum of the city. Music pulsed from the rooftop bar across the street, its crowd spilling out onto the temperature-controlled terrace.

“Beth’s different though,” Harry said, steadying his six-two frame against a lamppost, his constant gym routine evident in the way his shirt stretched across his chest. Even after all these years of friendship, I had to admit the bastard was annoyingly handsome—that perfect mix of dark features and blue eyes that made women do double-takes. Tonight, his black hair was perfectly dishevelled, and his easy confidence radiated through that trademark grin. No wonder Beth was already halfway in love with him.

“Not like—you know, what’s her name?” That familiar frown crossed his face, the one he got whenever he tried to remember his dating history. “Anyway, yeah. I like Beth. I think I’m really into her, I’m telling you.”

“You’re drunk,” I told him, punching in my building’s entry code. “And you’ve got that Cerulean contract presentation tomorrow.”

“Shit. Yeah.” He checked his phone. “You got all the code finished, right? I’ve just got to finish uploading the last few documents and we’ll be ready to go. I should have time. It’s not that late.”

“I had the code done last week,” I told him for the millionth time. “Go home and get it done. And don’t forget to message Beth and let her know you’re home safe. You promised you would. Even she could see how drunk you are.”

“I’m a terrible boyfriend, I know,” he slurred and then jabbed a finger in my direction. “And you’re just as terrible at actually sealing the deal with Sam,” he shot back, grinning. “How long are you gonna make that poor girl wait?”

“Get out of here,” I laughed, shoving him. “Text me when you’re home.”

“Will do,” he called as he started toward his building on the next block. “See you tomorrow at work.”

My phone buzzed as I watched him weave his way down the street.

It was Samantha.

Still up?

I replied: *Of course. Home now.*

Sam: *The meeting ran late. I’m in your area...*

I smiled, feeling the wine and the late hour and the promise in those three dots.

Me: *The door’s open. Figuratively speaking.*

The elevator carried me to my floor, and I tried not to think about work tomorrow. I wasn’t lying to Harry when I told him that I’d finished writing the code for the new Cerulean management app, but that was the only thing

I did have finished. A mountain of stuff was on my desk but now wasn't the time to worry about it. Sam was coming over, and that was all that mattered right now.

The apartment was a mess. Empty beer bottles from our pre-bar gaming session littered the coffee table, and Harry's jacket was still draped over my couch where he'd left it before we headed out. I'd meant to give it to him on the way home but had forgotten. Haley, the cleaner, would go mad with me tomorrow if I left it like this, and Sam wouldn't be impressed, so I did a quick sweep-up, cranked up the AC, and was just finishing hiding the evidence of our slovenly evening when the intercom chimed.

Sam looked good. Really good. She was the kind of beautiful that snuck up on you. Not model-stunning like blonde Beth, but all the sexier for it. Tonight, her brown hair fell in waves past her shoulders, and her work outfit was doing incredible things to her curves. Her marketing firm's dress code might have been strict, but that black pencil skirt and white blouse combination was definitely pushing some boundaries. Not that I was complaining. The skirt hugged her ass in a way that made my mouth dry, and the silk blouse was unbuttoned just enough to show a hint of cleavage. But it was her eyes that got me every time - deep hazel with flecks of gold that sparkled when she smiled.

"Productive meeting?" I asked, taking her laptop bag as she kicked off her heels.

"Productive enough to deserve a drink," she said, heading straight for the kitchen where she knew I kept the wine. "Did you boys have fun tonight?"

"Harry's officially lost it over Beth. He's naming their hypothetical children."

Sam laughed, returning with two glasses of 2024 Cabernet, a good year. "That's cute. Terrifying, but cute." She settled onto the couch beside me, close enough that I could smell her vanilla-esque perfume. "Though I guess some guys just know when they've found the right person."

There was a question in there somewhere, but I wasn't drunk enough or brave enough to address it. Instead, I reached for her hand, tracing small circles on her palm with my thumb. She leaned into me, and for a while, we just sat there, trading wine-flavoured kisses that grew increasingly less innocent as we watched TV.

A little time later, just as things were getting heated, she suddenly broke away, changing the mood with a random question.

“I’ve never noticed that before,” she said, pulling back slightly and nodding toward the picture on the wall. “You and Harry. When was that taken?”

The yacht photo. Everyone always noticed it eventually.

“Yeah, that’s us. I don’t remember exactly. A few years ago now. Before New York.”

Sam stood up, moving closer to the frame. “It’s weird...”

“What’s weird?”



“The composition.” She tilted her head, studying it. “There’s this empty space between you. Had you argued or something?”

Something cold slithered down my spine. “No,” I said, too quickly. “Just... bad photography, I guess.”

She turned back to me, her eyes curious. “You okay? You got really tense all of a sudden.”

I stood up, moving behind her, sliding my arms around her waist. “I’m fine,” I whispered against her neck. “Just distracted by how good you smell.”

It worked. She melted back against me, turning her head to capture my lips. The photo forgotten, we stumbled toward the bedroom, Sam’s hands at the buttons of my shirt, tugging it off, throwing it to one side. But like always, she pulled back just before things went too far.

“I want you,” she breathed, but her hand was already sliding down my chest, finding the bulge in my trousers. “But I’ve got an early meeting tomorrow...”

I fell backwards onto my bed, pulling her with me. The black pencil skirt rode up her smooth thighs as she straddled me, the wine making her bold. “You know what I think?” she whispered, rolling her hips, pressing herself against my growing hardness. “I think you want me bad.”

“Sam...” My hands found her thighs, sliding higher.

“Shhhh.” She unbuttoned her blouse slowly, revealing a white lace bra that barely contained her breasts. Taking my hands, she pressed them against the fabric of the cups. “Touch me.”

I felt the shape of her breasts, they were the perfect size, more than a handful. The heat of her soft skin radiated through the thin lace. I felt her nipples stiffen against my palms.

Her body was soft in all the right places, I’d imagined tasting every inch of her skin more times than I could count. Those long legs, that flat stomach, the curve of her hips... Jesus, the things this woman did to me without even trying. How had I not fucked her yet?

“Mmhmm,” was all I could manage as she reached down between her thighs, her hand finding my swelling erection. She knew exactly what she was doing, exactly how to drive me crazy.

“Wow. You’re so hard,” she whispered, squeezing my cock gently. “Maybe I should take care of this before I leave?”

“That’d be something,” I murmured.

She guided my hand under her skirt. Her panties were just as thin as the material of her bra. Her heat, a slight dampness that made me throb. “Fuck, Sam...”

But just as her fingers reached for my zipper, she pulled back with a wicked smile. “No... better not. Good things come to those who wait, right?”

I groaned in frustration, my erection straining painfully against my pants. “You’re evil.”

“You love it.” She kissed me deeply, then stepped away, smoothing her skirt and fastening her blouse. “I have to go. Sweet dreams.”

After she left, I sat in the dark for a while, too worked up to sleep. My cock was still hard, aching from her teasing. The wine buzz had faded to a

dull throb behind my eyes, and for some reason, that damn photo kept drawing my attention now that she'd pointed out the gap between us.

For some reason, my cock stirred again in my pants. Fuck it. I needed release.

I opened my laptop, pulling up my favourite porn site. The AI algorithm served up its usual recommendations, but something about tonight's selections felt different. A thumbnail caught my eye—a dark-haired woman with pale skin, brown eyes and a nice, curvy body with large, firm tits.

I clicked the video, already unzipping my pants. The woman was gorgeous, but it wasn't just that. There was something familiar about the way she moved, the curve of her neck, the sound of her voice. She reminded me of someone. Sam, maybe.

My cock was already in my hand, rock hard from Sam's teasing. The woman's moans filled the room as she begged to be taken. Something about her submission made my pulse race.

I watched as the dark-haired woman got on her knees, looking up at the camera with deep brown eyes that stirred something in my memory. Her pale skin, the way she bit her lip as she slid a finger into her shaved pussy...

I needed to save this one.

Right-clicking, I went to create a new folder but hesitated. I didn't want it showing up in my regular directories. A hidden folder, that's what I needed. But as I navigated through the file system, something strange appeared.

A directory I'd never seen before.

CHEAT_CODES

It was buried deep in the system architecture, somewhere it shouldn't be. My programmer knowledge told me this wasn't normal and wasn't part of the standard file structure.

The porn forgotten, I double-clicked the folder. A password prompt appeared, along with a single line of text:

"If you're reading this, you wanted to forget me."

What the fuck?

A cursor blinked, waiting for me to enter the password which would decrypt the folder but I had no idea what it was. Below the dialog box was a link to follow if the user wanted a password hint. I clicked it and the dialog box expanded with another message:

"What you seek lies in the space between you and what's behind you. To unlock these memories, take a good, long, hard look at yourself. Then turn

it all around. The answer is hiding where you'd never think to look—inside.”

My mouth went dry. What was this? Some sort of game that someone had planted on my computer? Something about the first message made my skin crawl. “If you’re reading this, you wanted to forget me.” What the hell did that mean?

“Take a look at yourself,” I said out loud, musing over the phrase in my head. Out of curiosity, I stood up, walked to the bathroom, the backlighting behind the mirror automatically glowing as I looked at my face, tired, lightly covered in a sheen of sweat from the heated kisses that Sam and I had shared.

But nothing happened. Of course it didn’t. What had I been expecting? A secret compartment to open behind it? A hidden door to reveal a room I’d never known existed?

I laughed at myself as I walked back to the laptop. What did the password hint mean? Was it someone fucking with me? Telling me to examine my life for some reason? I was still single, in my thirties, without much of a social life apart from a couple of friends and a girlfriend I was only just getting to know, even after a few months of dating.

Then I walked past it and froze. The picture. I pressed the button, turning on the frame’s built-in light for a moment and stared at it. Was it something to do with this?

I lifted it from the wall, walked over to my desk and set the frame down, suddenly distracted by the sound of sex; the porn video still playing forgotten in the background.

I thought about the password hint again. “What you seek lies in the space between you and what’s behind you.” The space between Harry and me was like a vacuum, drawing the eye. Harry wasn’t behind me, but still, could it be something to do with that?

“Then turn it all around.”

Turn it around? I flipped the frame over. There, written in unfamiliar handwriting: “07.13.31”

July 13th? 2031 was two years ago. Something about that date nagged at me, but I couldn’t place it. I’d been in New York by then, hadn’t I? Working with Harry at the new office? No. That was before I’d come here. Only by a couple of months, but before.

“The answer is hiding where you’d never think to look—inside.”

Inside... I ran my fingers along the frame's edge. The backing was loose in one corner. My heart was pounding now, though I couldn't explain why. With trembling fingers, I pried open the backing.

Something was written on the back of the photograph itself. Red ink, different handwriting than the date:

"CLAIRE_11_04_28"

Claire? The name meant nothing to me, but my stomach clenched when I read it for some reason. November 4th, 2028. That was when I lived back in DC. Harry and I both did. We'd moved to New York for the job, this date preceded that by years. What was happening?

Then I noticed the underscores. Why would someone write underscores when writing by hand?

I returned to my laptop and typed in the password.

CLAIRE_11_04_28

The folder opened.

The first file was named "README.txt"

My cursor hovered over it for a long moment before I clicked.

"Paul,

If you're reading this, you've already found the first password. Good. There's something you need to know: You've forgotten an entire chapter of your life. Not accidentally. Not through trauma. You paid to forget. A company called Elysium took your memories away. Replaced them with artificial ones.

You asked them to do it.

But before you went through with it, you left yourself these breadcrumbs. A way back, if you ever wanted to remember. If you ever needed to know the truth.

The next file contains a photograph. Study it carefully. When you understand what it means, you'll have the password to the next folder.

But Paul - be sure. Be very sure. Some things are better left forgotten. That's why you chose to forget them in the first place.

If you want to stop now, close this folder and walk away. Delete it. Go back to your life.

But if you need to know...

The photograph is waiting.

-P & C"

My hands were shaking as I opened the image file. The photo showed a hotel room—expensive and modern. On the bed lay a red dress, carefully arranged. Next to it, was a handwritten note, though the words were too blurred to read. Something about the scene made my chest tight.

I tried opening the next folder: MEMORY_01

Password required.

The cursor blinked, waiting.

Chapter Two

The lines of code on the screen blurred in front of me. I'd been staring at the same function for twenty minutes, my mind stuck on the photo I'd found last night. The hotel room. The red dress. What did it mean?

A half-empty cup of coffee grew cold beside my keyboard. Across the open-plan office, developers hunched over their monitors like digital monks, all of us preparing for today's Cerulean Hotels pitch. The prototype guest management system had consumed our lives for months. Now, hours before the biggest presentation of the year, I couldn't focus on a single line of code.

My phone buzzed. Sam.

Free for dinner tonight?

I started typing "Yes," and then stopped. How could I think about dating when my whole life felt as confusing as the screen full of code before me?

Can we raincheck? Deadline stuff.

Three dots appeared, disappeared, appeared again.

Sure. Tomorrow?

"Morning meeting?" Rachel's voice made me jump. She perched on the edge of my desk, elegant in a cream blazer that set off her red hair. Rachel had started at the company the same time as Harry and me, and somehow she'd become our unofficial handler, smoothing over our technical edges with her smooth charm. "You look... seem... somewhere else today."

"Just tired. Late night."

“With Sam?” A perfectly arched eyebrow raised slightly. Something about her interest felt wrong, but before I could analyze it, Marcus appeared beside us, holo-tablet clutched to his chest like a shield.

“Paul!” His wire-rimmed glasses slid down his nose as he spoke. “Thank god. I think I found a major security flaw in the authentication module, and Harry’s about to present it to James Wilson himself, and—“

“Breathe, Marcus,” Rachel said, standing smoothly. “The code will still be broken after the meeting.” She checked her watch. “Which started three minutes ago, by the way. We can fix it later. No one is pretending that the app is finished.”

Marcus Chen had been our security specialist for the past year. Brilliant, anxious, and perpetually convinced everything was about to collapse. Usually, I’d have spent an hour talking him down, but today...

“Show me on the way,” I said, grabbing my laptop. We hurried down the corridor and as we approached the conference room, I saw Harry working the room. He’d already gotten James Wilson to laugh, which was a good sign, and we hadn’t even started the technical demo yet. The CEO of Cerulean Hotels lounged in his chair like he owned the place—which, given the size of this potential contract, he practically did. His security consultant, Robert Hayes, looked less impressed, tapping notes into his holo-tablet with quick, sharp movements.

Marcus was still muttering about encryption protocols when Rachel ushered us inside. “Sorry we’re late,” she said smoothly. “Last-minute security verification.”

Harry shot me a questioning look as I slid into a seat. I gave him a thumbs up, trying to focus. The prototype’s user interface gleamed on the main screen, all sleek and ultra-efficient design. Months of work, countless late nights, and enough coffee to float a battleship, all leading to this moment.

“As I was saying,” Harry continued, “The software memory-mapping algorithm learns from each hotel guest’s stay, creating an evolving digital profile that—“

The click of heels in the hallway cut through his words like a knife.

Victoria Nash stood in the doorway, a study in power and beauty combined. Her ash-blond hair was swept into an elegant chignon, emphasising her razor-sharp cheekbones and those infamous ice-blue eyes. The charcoal suit probably cost more than my monthly salary, tailored to

hug curves that had no doubt featured in more than a few executive's fantasies. She was around forty but radiated the kind of sexual confidence that came from knowing exactly how attractive you were and exactly how to use it.

The room's atmosphere shifted instantly—even Wilson sat up straighter. Victoria and her company were another of our major investors, and her presence commanded attention like gravity.

"You don't mind me sitting in, do you?" she said, though it wasn't really a question. Her voice carried that hint of a cultivated accent that spoke of European finishing schools and old money. "I was in the building for another matter, but when I heard about this presentation..." She smiled, her ice-blue eyes finding mine for just a moment too long, stirring something in my memory that refused to surface, her voice, saying something about solutions, about fresh starts... I couldn't remember what. Maybe I was imagining it.

"Of course not," Wilson said quickly. "Always a pleasure, Victoria. I didn't realize Nash Ventures had an interest in hotel management systems."

"Oh, I'm interested in all sorts of things, James." She took a seat directly opposite me. "Especially when it comes to the latest memory tech."

Harry cleared his throat. "Right. So, Paul, would you like to walk us through the security protocols?"

I stood, mouth dry. Victoria's mention of memory tech was jarring. It had to be a coincidence that she'd just brought up the word *memory*. Right?

I shook off the weird feeling that was bugging me and worked through the security protocols on autopilot, hyperaware of Victoria's gaze. She crossed her long legs, reminding me of someone else—a flash of pale thighs, someone saying something about *the last time*... But the memory slipped away before I could grasp it.

"Impressive," Wilson said when we finished. "Though I notice your biometric tracking system has certain... gaps in data retention."

"By design," Harry jumped in. "Some things are better left private. We shouldn't track everything they do. You know what people get up to in hotel rooms, yes?"

Victoria's laugh was like cut crystal. "And what is that, Harry?" Her eyes flickered between us, amusement curving her full lips as she teased him. "Would you care to go into more detail?"

Fortunately, Marcus stepped in to fill in the final details about the app, delivery times, and costs, saving Harry's blushes. Soon after that, the meeting wrapped up with handshakes and promises of follow-up calls. As the clients filed out, Beth appeared in the doorway, stunning in a form-fitting dress that made my throat tight. The sight of her sent a guilty jolt through me, as it often did.

"Thought I'd surprise you for lunch," she said to Harry, kissing him softly once everyone had left. Her perfume filled the room—the same scent she'd worn that night, explaining my discomfort. "You too, Paul, if you're free?"

"Actually," Harry checked his phone, "I've got a follow-up with Hayes. I'm really sorry. Maybe tomorrow?"

"Awwww." Beth's dark eyes met mine. "Just you and me then, Paul?"

The way she said my name made my cock twitch. I shouldn't be alone with her. Not after what we'd done. Not with the way she looked in that dress, making me think how easily it would slide up her thighs...

"I'd love to," I heard myself say.

Harry headed to his meeting, and Rachel watched us leave, her expression unreadable. Behind her, Victoria was still in the conference room, speaking quietly into her phone. As Beth and I waited for the elevator, I could have sworn I heard her say "Elysium." My imagination was definitely playing tricks on me.

I needed to figure out the puzzle at home, work through this ridiculous Cheat Codes game that someone had left on my PC and get all of this out of my head before it became too much of a distraction and drove me any crazier than it already had.

A short time later, Beth chose a quiet corner table at Le Petit, the French bistro across the street. She ordered wine with lunch, her eyes sparkling with mischief again. The dress she wore was criminally tight, clinging to curves that made my mouth dry. Her dyed blonde hair fell past her shoulders, and she had this way of touching it absently that drew attention to her neck, making me remember how she tasted there.

"So," she said, a familiar glint in her eye. "You and Sam. Talk to me. Have you fucked her yet?"

"Jesus, Beth."

"What? I'm curious." She leaned forward, giving me a view of lace-trimmed cleavage that made my pulse quicken. "She's hot. Those lips... I

bet she gives amazing head.”

“Can we not?”

“Harry avoids me. Then you’re no fun anymore. What’s a girl to do for some amusement around here?” But her smile faded slightly. “Okay, let’s be serious then. I’m glad I got you alone. I wanted to talk. Harry’s been... weird lately. Talking in his sleep.”

I focused on my salad, trying not to stare at her lips as she sipped her wine. “Yeah?”

“He’s having bad dreams. Mumbling, mentioning names I don’t recognise. Places that I presume are back in DC. Last night he kept saying something about it being expensive and risky. He wakes up sweating but won’t tell me what’s up. Has he said anything to you?”

“It’s probably just stress from the Cerulean project,” I suggested. “He’s been under a lot of pressure to get this app up and running. The presentation today was important to him. To all of us.”

“Are you sure that’s all it is?” She shrugged, making her breasts bounce pleasantly in her dress, but I could tell something was bothering her. Then she came out with it. “Do you know anyone called Ann Or Marie?”

The name meant nothing to me. I shook my head. “I don’t. I wouldn’t worry about it, Beth. He’s crazy into you. I shouldn’t tell you this, but he was telling me how much he likes you last night. As in... you know, *really* likes you.”

“Aww.” Her brown eyes twinkled, and she couldn’t help but grin. “Well, that’s comforting, I guess. Maybe I’m reading too much into it, but listen... if he does say anything to you... About this Ann woman, you’d tell me, right?”

“Of course,” I nodded, although I wasn’t sure if I would break Harry’s confidence. “I’ll talk to him, make sure everything’s okay.”

“Because we’re friends, right?” Her dark eyes softened, gazing into mine. There was a vulnerability there. She really liked him too. It was obvious. “After what happened between us, we’re close, you and I, aren’t we?”

“Sure.” I tried to reassure her, wishing she hadn’t reminded me of that night. The rest of lunch was careful small talk, but the air between us crackled with familiar tension. Every time she bit her lip or played with her hair, I remembered how she’d felt beneath me, the sounds she’d made. My mind was troubled enough with the photograph awaiting me at home. I didn’t need her to reinforce the guilt I was feeling.

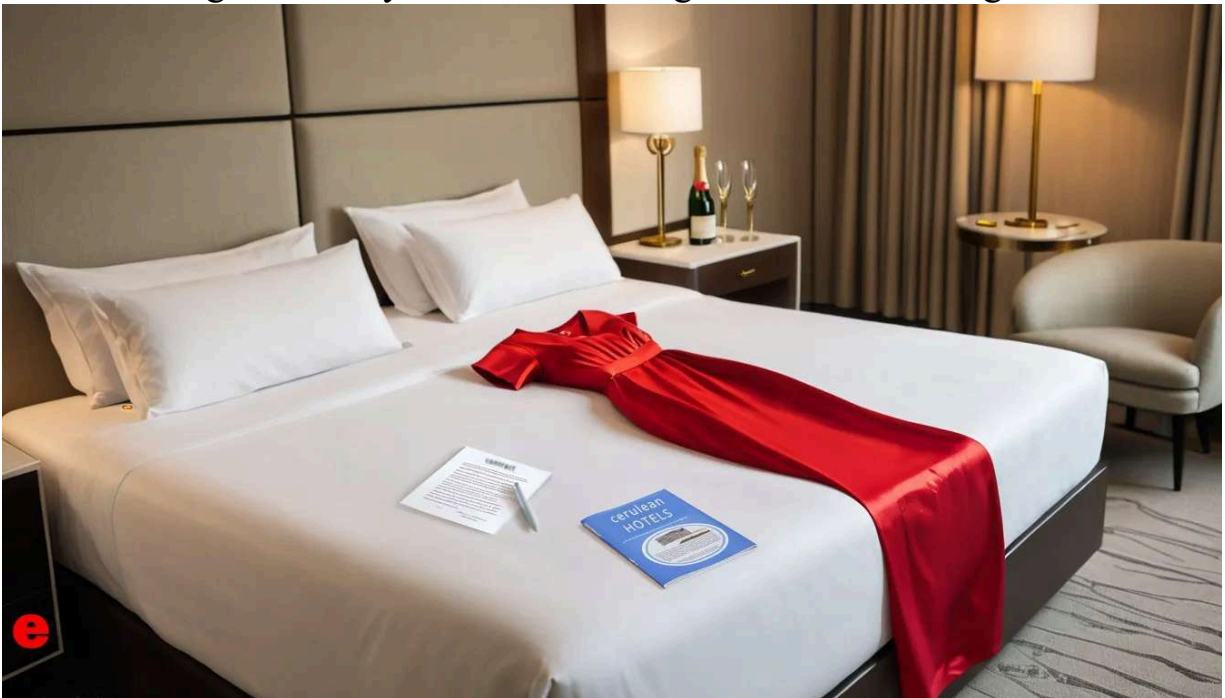
After a delicious lunch, I thanked Beth for lunch and headed back to work, managing to find my focus and push through the afternoon's workload. When I got home, in my building's lobby, I passed Haley finishing up her Thursday cleaning rounds. She looked hassled today—her honey-blond hair tied back in a messy bun, curve-hugging yoga pants beneath her cleaning company polo shirt. Not for the first time, I wondered why someone who looked like her—tall, stacked, gorgeous—was working as a cleaner. Then again, I didn't know much about her or what her situation was.

"All done upstairs, Mr. Lacuna," she said with her usual bright smile, a hint of something knowing in her expression. "Changed the sheets like you asked."

"Thanks, Haley. You're a lifesaver." I wondered why she gave me the look she did. Was she presuming I'd asked her to change the sheets because I'd had sex or something? I wished I had, but I hadn't.

I tried not to watch her walk away, but it was impossible not to notice how her hips swayed. What was wrong with me? Sam's teasing last night must have been more effective than I'd realised.

I stepped inside, kicking off my shoes, loosened my tie, pouring a whisky before settling on the couch with my laptop, bringing up the photo that had been haunting me all day. It was time to figure this damn thing out.



I zoomed in, letting the image fill my screen. The hotel room looked expensive—modern furnishings, soft lighting, and a king-size bed with crisp white sheets. My eyes were drawn immediately to the red dress laid across it. Not thrown there in passion, but arranged deliberately, almost ceremonially.

Something about the dress nagged at me. Not just its presence, but its purpose. It was waiting for someone. Ready for something to begin. I studied it. No. Wait. It was slightly creased. Worn and taken off. Not laid out ready to wear.

I zoomed in on the bed next. A hotel brochure sat there, its logo clearly visible: Cerulean Hotels. My stomach tightened. What were the chances? The same hotel chain we'd pitched to today? Then again, it was a huge chain. Not that huge of a coincidence when I thought about it.

The champagne bottle on the nightstand caught my eye next. Unopened, perfectly positioned beside two empty glasses. Not one. Like whoever set this scene wasn't planning to drink alone. Like they were waiting for someone else to arrive.

Then I noticed something else. In the bottom left corner of the photo, a small red 'e' logo, had been added digitally. I'd been so focused on the dress that I'd almost missed it. Was it a watermark? Added by the company who'd taken the picture, perhaps? Or had the person leaving me this puzzle added it? If so, why? What was its significance?

I took another sip of whisky, studying the blurred note on the bed now. The writing was illegible, but it looked formal, less like a letter and more like... I wasn't sure. There was a heading and at the bottom, I could just make out what might be signature lines. Was it an agreement of some kind?

The next file contains a photograph. Study it carefully. When you understand what it means, you'll have the password to the next folder.

The photograph is waiting.

When you understand what it means... It must be about a person. The person this scene was arranged for. The woman who would wear that dress. The one who would drink that champagne. The one who was waiting...

The one who was...

Ready.

The word flickered through my mind. That red 'e' in the corner. Wait...

Red-e.

My hands shook slightly as I opened the password prompt. Too simple, surely? But something about it felt right. The whole scene was about anticipation, about preparation.

I typed: “ready”

Access denied.

I stared at the dress again, at how carefully it was arranged. This wasn’t just about being ready. This was about someone declaring their readiness. Making a statement.

The ReadMe file was asking me if I was ready. I understood.

I typed again: “I’m ready”

The screen flickered. A new window opened.

Inside was a video file named “FIRST_NIGHT.mp4” and a text document: “READ_THIS_FIRST.txt”

My cursor hovered over the text file. Through my apartment windows, the sunset painted everything in shades of red, like the dress in the photo. Like the ‘e’ in the corner. It felt like a warning sign. Should I continue? A nagging voice in my head repeated the words in the note.

Some things are better left forgotten. That’s why you chose to forget them in the first place.

If you want to stop now, close this folder and walk away. Delete it. Go back to your life.

Fuck. Was I making a mistake?

I clicked the ReadMe file. The message was short:

“You solved it. Good. But before you watch the video, understand this: What you’re about to see is what started everything. It’s why you chose to forget. It’s why I left these breadcrumbs.

And Paul?

I’m sorry for what comes next.”

Chapter Three

“I ’m sorry for what comes next.”

What the hell was going on? I looked again at the video file: FIRST_NIGHT.mp4.

Should I do this? I had to. I double-clicked the icon. The video began playing, and my world stopped.

A woman sat on a hotel bed—the same bed from the photograph. The red dress lay beside her, but she wore only black lingerie, her dark hair falling past her shoulders. She was beautiful in a way that made my chest ache, though I couldn’t see her face clearly—she was adjusting the phone camera, angling it to look down at her body..

“Is this thing on?” Her voice sent a jolt through me. Familiar. Impossibly familiar.

She settled back, and I finally saw her face. Dark eyes, dark hair. Full lips curved into a nervous smile. Her body was slender but curved in all the right places, the black lace barely containing full breasts that I guessed were a perfect handful. The lingerie hugged her narrow waist, accentuating the curve of her hips.

“Paul...” she began, and my name in her mouth felt like a key turning in a lock. “I wanted to record this before... well, before everything starts.”

She twisted a gold band on her finger—a wedding ring. My pulse hammered in my ears.

“I love you,” she said simply. “I need you to remember that, no matter what happens tonight. This was your idea at first, but now I want it too. I’ve

been thinking about it constantly.”

Her hands moved to her hair, tucking it behind her ear in a gesture so achingly familiar I almost reached toward the screen.

“I’m nervous,” she admitted, laughing softly. “But excited too. God, I’m so wet just thinking about it.” She bit her lip, looking directly into the camera. “About him. About you watching.”

She leaned closer, her breasts pressing together, creating a deep cleavage that made my mouth dry. Her voice dropped to a whisper. “Thank you for letting me do this. For understanding what I need.” She slipped the ring off her finger, holding it up. “Still yours. Always yours. But tonight...”

She reached behind her, tucking the ring behind the pillow. The symbolism wasn’t subtle.

“I’ll record it all and show you the video later,” she promised, her smile turning wicked. “After. When you’re inside me again, reclaiming what’s yours.”

She blew a kiss to the camera. “See you soon. I hope you’re enjoying me teasing you like this.”

As she reached to turn off the recording, a man’s voice came from somewhere off-camera.

“Hi, Claire.”

The video ended.

I sat frozen, my heart thundering. Claire. The name echoed through me, finding nothing to connect to. But my body remembered - the arousal burning through me was primal, instinctive. I’d watched this woman—my wife... ex-wife?—prepare to sleep with another man. With my knowledge. My permission. My encouragement.

Beneath the video player was another file: “ENTRY_01.encrypted”

And a password prompt with a single hint: “Who was first?”

I stared at the screen, my mind racing. Claire. Who was she? She was the woman I’d chosen to forget if this was to be believed. And she’d been with someone else—with my blessing.

“Who was first?” The question mocked me. Who was first... what? The first guy to sleep with her? I had no idea. But whatever—whoever—it was had shaken me enough to erase my own memories.

I tried random names. John. Mike. David. Nothing worked. That was futile. I’d be here all night. No, I needed help. My fingers hovered over my

phone. Sam? No way I could explain this to her. Marcus? He'd think I was insane. That left Harry.

My call went to voicemail. "Harry, it's me. I need to talk. It's important."

I paced my apartment, the video playing on a loop in my mind: Claire removing her ring, her voice, her smile, a ghost I couldn't remember but who seemed unnervingly familiar.

Twenty minutes later, I gave up waiting and grabbed my keys. Harry's apartment was only fifteen blocks away.

I pressed the button on the doorbell. Twice. No response, but I could hear music thumping from inside—some old-school rock ballad with the volume cranked. I tried again. Nothing.

I tried pressing my thumb to his biometric doorbell, watched the blue scan line read my print, and heard the door unlock. Harry had given me access to the place while he'd gone on vacation but had never removed my data. I knew he was inside from the music. He'd just got it too loud to hear me.

"Harry?" I called, pushing the door open slightly. The rock ballad swallowed my voice, so I stepped into the hallway, moving toward the sound. The bedroom door was partially open, and I froze when I reached it.

Beth was naked, straddling an equally naked Harry on the bed, sideways to the door, moving in a slow rhythm that made her blonde hair cascade down her bare back. Harry's hands gripped her hips, guiding her movements. Neither had heard me over the music pounding out of the ceiling audio-portal.

I should have announced myself immediately. Should have backed away. Instead, I stood motionless, watching Beth's body rise and fall. She was incredibly sexy—smooth skin flushed with pleasure, the curve of her spine arching as she ground against him. Her firm, perky breasts jutting out in front of her, her dark pink nipples standing proudly as she fucked him. Harry's expression was one of pure bliss, his eyes closed, completely lost in the feeling of her shaved pussy.

Something about the situation, maybe the way his bedroom door remained open even with music playing... it almost felt like he wouldn't mind being seen. Like showing off was part of the thrill. Beth, though—I wasn't so sure.

The guilt hit me like a wave, but I still couldn't look away. They moved together urgently, Harry rising to meet her as she pushed down on his thick

cock, Beth whispering things I couldn't hear. Them both moaning, sounds that made my cock stiffen despite myself.

Beth was a good fuck. The night we'd spent together had been awesome, and I could see now that it wasn't a one-off. She was fucking Harry so good, his toes were curling with pleasure.

I finally took a deliberate step back, clearing my throat loudly, then called out, loud enough for them to hear, "Harry? You home?" I waited a beat, then stepped into view, still catching them in the act, surprisingly.

"Jesus Christ!" Harry pushed Beth to the side, grabbing for the sheet. "Paul! Shit!"

Beth didn't scream or cover herself immediately. Instead, she turned slowly, those dark eyes finding mine with an expression I couldn't read. Only then did she pull the sheet up, not embarrassed, deliberately slowly.

"Sorry," I managed, backing away further. "The door was unlocked. I called but..."

"Wait in the living room," Harry said, his voice tight. "Give us a minute."

I retreated, leaving him with his face burning. My cock was still hard from seeing them fuck. I knew how Beth felt, how she tasted, the noises she made as she came. It was hard not to think about it, but I forced myself to push the thoughts from my mind, to concentrate on why I was here.

Five long minutes later, Harry emerged in shorts and a T-shirt, Beth behind him in one of his shirts, a sexy look, seeming remarkably composed for someone who'd just been caught mid-fuck.

"This better be good," Harry said, running a hand through his dishevelled hair.

"It is. Although it's a bit weird. I need to ask you something," I said, my mouth dry. "Do you know anyone named Claire? A woman I used to date?"

Harry's brow furrowed. "Claire? Don't think so. Why?"

Beth perched on the arm of the couch, her legs impossibly long beneath Harry's shirt. She'd buttoned it just enough to be decent, but not enough to let me forget what was underneath. Her eyes never left my face.

"What about Elysium? Ever heard of them?"

A flicker of recognition crossed Harry's face. "The memory tech company? Skin Deep stuff, right? They've been all over the news."

"Skin Deep?"

"Yeah, their memory transfer tech. People selling experiences to each other. Want to know what it feels like to summit Everest without the effort?"

Buy the memory. Want to experience a parachute drop without jumping from a plane? There's a memory for that." He shrugged. "Crazy expensive. Mostly for the ultra-rich. Why are you asking about this?"

I hesitated. How much should I tell him?

"I found something on my computer. Files I don't remember creating. Photos, videos... of a woman named Claire." I swallowed. "I think she was my wife."

Beth's eyebrows shot up.

"Your wife?" Harry laughed, then stopped when he saw my expression. "Wait, you're serious? Dude, you've never been married."

"How do you know?"

"Because I've known you for years. Since college."

Had he? I tried to remember our college days, but the memories felt strangely flat, like photos rather than experiences.

"What about memory removal?" I asked. "Does Elysium do that?"

Harry's amusement faded. "That would be illegal as hell. Selling memories is one thing. Erasing them? That's messing with identity, personhood. It would be like lobotomy 2.0."

"But theoretically possible?"

He exchanged a look with Beth. "I guess? But wildly dangerous. You'd be... I dunno, risking brain damage, personality changes, psychosis. Why would anyone want that?"

To forget the unforgivable. The thought came unbidden, and I wasn't sure if it was my own.

"Look," I said, pulling out my phone. "I need to show you something."

I logged into my home PC and played the video. Harry watched with increasing discomfort while Beth's expression grew more intense, almost hungry for details.

"That's..." Harry began when it ended.

"My wife," I finished. "A wife I don't remember having."

"Or some elaborate prank," Harry countered. "Deep fakes are everywhere. This isn't so different. Someone's fucking with you."

"Who? And why?"

"I don't know. Jealous coworker? Crazy ex? Some hacker who got into your system?" He ran a hand through his hair. "But memory wiping? Come on, man. That's science fiction."

Beth had been silent, but now she spoke. “The thing is... Harry, you’ve been having strange dreams lately. Names you say you don’t recognise. Places you insist you’ve never been.”

Harry shot her a look. “That’s just stress dreams. Nightmares. Whatever. We talked about this.”

“It’s more than that,” she insisted, turning back to me. “Last week, he called out a woman’s name in his sleep. I told you about it.”

“Annmarie,” I said, remembering the name.

Harry froze. “How do you know that name?”

I stared at him, my pulse racing. “I don’t. Beth told me earlier. One of the names you’d mentioned in your sleep.”

“I know that name,” Harry murmured. “But...”

The three of us sat in tense silence, the implications hanging between us like smoke.

“This is crazy,” Harry finally said. “It’s some sort of game, that’s all. Someone’s messing with you. With us.”

But I could see the doubt in his eyes.

“Maybe so,” I said, not wanting to push him further. Harry was rattled, though he was trying to hide it. “But I need to figure out what’s going on.”

“What’s the next step in this... whatever it is?” Beth asked, leaning forward. Her shirt gaped slightly, showing the shape of her breasts. I forced myself to look away. “The video must lead somewhere. To another clue or whatever.”

I nodded. “There’s another file, but it’s password protected. The hint is ‘Who was first?’”

“First what?” Harry asked.

“First... man she was with. Besides me.” The words tasted strange. “I think. I don’t know. It’s all so cryptic. But this whole thing—the folder is called ‘CHEAT_CODES.’ I think it’s literal. I think it’s about her cheating.”

“With your permission,” Beth noted. “She said it was your idea.”

Something cold settled in my stomach. “Yeah.”

Harry stood suddenly, pacing. “This is insane. You don’t have a wife. You’ve never had a wife. I would know.” He stopped, running both hands through his hair. “Wouldn’t I?”

The question hung in the air.

“I should go,” I said, standing. “I’ve got a lot to figure out. I’ll leave to, uh, finish what you started.”

Beth grinned, and Harry walked me to the door, his girlfriend trailing behind. “Listen,” he said quietly, “be careful with this. If someone’s messing with you, they’ve gone to extreme lengths. That’s not normal.”

I nodded. “I’ll call you tomorrow.”

As I turned to leave, Beth touched my arm. “Try your own name,” she said softly. “Maybe it’s that simple.”

I felt Harry’s eyes on us both. “Yeah. Maybe you were this Claire’s first. I don’t know.”

Outside, the night air cleared my head a little. I walked instead of taking a cab, needing time to process. Harry’s reaction to the name ‘Annmarie’ confirmed there was something weird going on here, whether he admitted it or not.

Back home, I opened my laptop again, staring at the password prompt.

“Who was first?” I said aloud, wracking my brain to no avail.

I tried basic names: John, Michael, David, James.

Nothing.

I tried Beth’s suggestion: Paul.

Nothing.

Harry? Annmarie?

Nothing.

I tried variations of Elysium and combinations of everything I knew.

Nothing.

By 3 AM, my eyes were burning. I stared at the prompt, the cursor blinking like a taunt. If this was true, somewhere in my forgotten past was a name—the first man my supposedly forgotten wife had slept with while I watched. The first step down a path that had led to... what? Memory erasure? Divorce? Both?

I closed the laptop, rubbing my face. I tried a hundred names. This wasn’t working. I needed more information. Guessing wasn’t enough.

I grabbed a notebook and began writing down what I knew:

- Claire was my wife.
- We were into some sort of kinky wife-sharing stuff.
- It started at a Cerulean Hotel.
- The first man’s name is the password.

- Harry knows the name “Annmarie” but claims not to.

Then, I added what I needed to find out:

- Who is Annmarie? The name didn’t mean anything to me.
- Where is Claire now?
- Why did we choose to forget?

I stared at my list, exhaustion finally overtaking frustration. Tomorrow, I’d dig deeper. I’d search for Claire Lacuna. I’d look into Elysium beyond their public Skin Deep program. I’d find out who the hell Annmarie was and why her name meant something to Harry.

Someone had either decided to fuck with me and create an elaborate game. Or they’d gone to extraordinary lengths to make me forget my past. Either way, they’d also left a solution—a way back. A trail of breadcrumbs.

And I was going to follow it.

All the way to the truth.

Chapter Four

The password prompt stared back at me like a taunt.
“Who was first?”

I was remotely logged into my home computer from work, trying combinations all morning instead of working on the Cerulean Hotels security protocols. Nothing worked. Combinations of my own name, as Beth had suggested, with other words and names. Combinations of everything I could think of. Dates and more. Still nothing.

I rubbed my eyes, feeling the effects of a mostly sleepless night. The face of the woman—Claire—haunted me. A wife I couldn’t remember, preparing to sleep with another man in a hotel room. With my blessing. The cognitive dissonance was giving me a headache.

“Earth to Paul.”

Rachel stood beside my desk, her presence so sudden I nearly jumped. She wore a gray pencil skirt and cream blouse that complemented her red hair, which fell in perfect waves around her shoulders. I quickly minimized the window on my screen.

“Sorry,” I managed. “Miles away.”

“I can see that.” She perched her slim rear on the edge of my desk, studying me with genuine concern. “You okay? You look exhausted.”

“Fine. I just didn’t sleep well.”

“Work pressures keeping you up?” Her eyes held mine a beat longer than necessary. “Or something else?”

There was something about the way she asked—a hint of something beyond casual interest. I'd always found Rachel attractive, with her sharp intelligence and subtle confidence, but I'd always maintained a careful professional distance. Why, I didn't really know. She was good-looking.

"Just one of those nights," I said vaguely. "Brain wouldn't shut off."

"I know what that's like." She tilted her head, red hair shifting across her shoulder, falling over the shape of one her breasts. "Have you tried meditation? Or..." Her lips curved in a slight smile, "Other relaxation techniques?"

Before I could respond to the teasing innuendo, Harry appeared, looking nearly as exhausted as I felt. His usually immaculate shirt was slightly wrinkled, and dark circles shadowed his eyes.

"Morning," he mumbled, reaching for my coffee and taking a sip without asking.

Rachel's attention shifted to him, her forehead creasing slightly. "You too? Did no one in this office sleep last night?"

Harry gave a noncommittal shrug. "Working on the presentation."

"Well, it paid off," she said, watching him carefully. "James Wilson just called. We got the contract."

Harry's expression brightened momentarily. "Seriously? Full package?"

"Every bit of it. The board are thrilled." Rachel glanced between us. "You both should be proud."

"That's... that's amazing," Harry said, but the enthusiasm seemed forced. His eyes met mine briefly, a silent question passing between us. You okay?

I nodded slightly. He looked relieved.

"I should tell Marcus before he has a coronary over that authentication bug," Harry said, already backing away. "Later."

Rachel watched him go, then turned back to me. "What was that about?"

"What?"

"That look between you two. Is something going on I should know about?"

I kept my expression neutral. "Just guy stuff. Nothing important."

"Wait," she giggled, her fine eyebrows arching, "Did you two... Are you two...?"

"No, we're not gay," I laughed, in spite of myself. Rachel's humour could be infectious sometimes.

“Hmm.” She smiled but didn’t tease any further. Instead, she shifted closer, her knee brushing against mine. “We should celebrate. How about drinks tonight? Just the two of us?”

The invitation hung in the air between us, obvious in its intent. She was flirting. Her green eyes held mine, a slight smile playing at the corners of her mouth.

“It’d be good,” she continued when I didn’t immediately respond. “We’ve worked together for what—two years now? And I feel like I hardly know you outside of code and client meetings.”

There was something almost wistful in her tone that caught me off guard. Had Rachel always been interested, and I’d been too oblivious to notice? Or was she being purely platonic, and I was just reading too much into it?

“I can’t tonight,” I said, remembering my plans. “I promised Sam dinner. We’ve been... I’ve been distracted lately. I can’t let her down.”

“Of course,” she said, sliding gracefully off my desk. “Another time, then.”

“Sure,” I nodded, feeling a sense of relief for some reason. “As friends, of course.”

Was that disappointment in her green eyes? She adjusted her skirt, smoothing imaginary wrinkles over her slim thighs. “The offer stands. Whenever you’re free.”

I watched her walk away, her heels tapping against the floor. Under different circumstances—before Sam, before this mysterious Claire—I might have said yes. In fact—watching her hips swaying with each step—I’d have said yes without hesitation.

With a sigh, I turned back to my screen and reopened the remote desktop to my home computer and the annoying password prompt.

“Who was first?”

The cursor blinked mockingly, a digital timer counting the seconds of my frustration.

Somewhere in my forgotten past was a name—the first man my wife had slept with. The first step down a path that had led to memory erasure. What kind of life had I lived? And why had I chosen to forget it?

The afternoon crawled by, each minute stretching impossibly long as I obsessed over the password. Even the celebration of landing the Cerulean contract felt distant, happening to someone else while my real life was trapped in that encrypted file.

By five, I'd managed to make minimal progress on the security module, just enough that Marcus wouldn't panic. I'd have a more productive day tomorrow, I promised myself.

"Heading out?" Rachel appeared at my desk again as I was shutting down my computer. "Did you manage to get to the bottom of the bug?"

"I think so," I said, gathering my things. "I'll figure it out. I always do."

"Mmmm." She perched on my desk once again, smoothing her skirt. "So where are you taking Sam tonight?"

"Dinner at Luciano's. Drink after, maybe."

Something flickered across her face—jealousy, maybe? "Lucky girl. Their carbonara is legendary."

"We'll have to try it," I said, immediately regretting how it could be misperceived as an invitation. I meant 'we' as Sam and I, but it'd be rude to point that out now.

Rachel smiled, tucking a strand of red hair behind her ear. "Maybe we will." She stood, straightening to her full height in those impossibly high heels. "Have a good night, Paul. Don't do anything I wouldn't do."

As she walked away, I couldn't help but watch her again. *Stop*, I told myself. I shook the thoughts of temptation away. Sam was waiting, and I'd already been a distracted boyfriend lately. She deserved better.

At home, I saw Haley, the cleaner and paid her weekly wages, then showered and changed, trying to focus on the evening ahead rather than the password problem. I chose a blue button-down that Sam had once said brought out my eyes, dark jeans, and a sports jacket that didn't scream "trying too hard" but still looked like I'd made an effort.

Luciano's was busy when I arrived, the Friday night crowd filling the rustic Italian restaurant with laughter and the clinking of wine glasses. Sam was already at the table, looking gorgeous in a simple black dress. Her brown hair fell in loose waves past her shoulders, and she'd added just enough makeup to enhance her natural beauty without distracting from it.

"Hey," I said, leaning down to kiss her. She smelled amazing—a floral perfume, not overpowering.

"Hey yourself," she smiled, eyes cutely crinkling at the corners. "I wondered if you might cancel on me last minute again."

"Not a chance." I slid into the seat across from her. "I've been looking forward to this all day."

It wasn't entirely a lie. Part of me had been looking forward to this—to something normal, uncomplicated by missing memories and mysterious ex-wives that might or might not exist.

"Wine?" Sam offered, lifting a bottle of Chianti the server had already opened.

"Please."

As she poured, I found myself studying her features—the curve of her cheek, the shape of her lips, the way her hazel eyes caught the candlelight. Had I been drawn to her because she reminded me of Claire somehow? The thought unsettled me. Their colouring was similar, and there was something in Sam's mannerisms, the way she tucked her hair behind her ear...

"Hello," Sam said, waving her hand in front of my face. "Where'd you go just now?"

"Sorry," I said, forcing a smile. "Just thinking how beautiful you look tonight."

She blushed slightly, pleased but not entirely convinced. "Thank you. But seriously, what's going on with you lately? You've been a million miles away. Is it the presentation?"

I took a long sip of wine, buying time. How much could I tell her? How much *should* I tell her?

"Work stuff mostly," I hedged. "The Cerulean contract was a big deal."

"Which you landed today, right?" Her smile widened. I'd texted her the news earlier. "That's worth celebrating!"

The server arrived to take our orders, providing a welcome interruption. Sam chose the risotto, I went with the carbonara Rachel had mentioned. When we were alone again, Sam leaned forward, her expression softening.

"We've only been dating a few months," she said. "But I'm here if you want to share whatever's weighing you down. I can tell something's bothering you."

Her kindness pierced through my defenses. Maybe I could tell her something—not everything, but enough.

"There is something. Something I found on my computer," I said carefully. "You're going to find this weird."

"What is it?"

"A folder I don't remember creating. It's password-protected with riddles and puzzles. It's... well, it's really weird. I don't know what to think of it."

Sam tilted her head, curiosity piqued. “Are you saying someone hacked you?”

“Maybe. I don’t know. I don’t think so.” I swirled the wine in my glass. “In the text files, there’s this company mentioned—Elysium. Have you heard of them?”

“The memory tech company?” Sam’s eyes widened. “I read about them. The Skin Deep thing, right? People buying and selling experiences like commodities. Creepy but fascinating.”

“Exactly. But I think there might be more to it than what’s public.”

“Like what?”

I hesitated, then decided to test the waters. “What if they could remove memories, not just share them? What if they could replace them—permanently—with fake memories? Like the original memory never existed?”

Sam laughed, then stopped when she saw my expression. “That’s science fiction, Paul. And ethically horrifying. Why would anyone want to forget a part of their lives?”

“I’m fairly sure most people have things they’d want to forget. Bad things. Painful things.”

Her hazel eyes studied me intently. “Okay. But... what are you suggesting? What’s that got to do with this weird folder?”

I didn’t speak. I didn’t know how to even begin telling her the rest of it.

“Are you saying... that someone erased your memories?”

The question hung between us. I couldn’t tell if she thought I was joking, crazy, or onto something legitimate.

“It sounds insane when you say it out loud,” I admitted.

“A little,” she agreed, but her smile was gentle. “So what exactly was in there to make you think that?”

I sighed, not wanting to go into it for obvious reasons. “A photo of something I don’t remember. It’s not important. But the thing is... why would I—or someone else—leave me a folder like that? Unless I wanted myself to remember? And if I did, why the hell did I want to forget it in the first place? And if it’s someone else playing a dumb game, why are they fucking around with me?”

“I don’t know,” Sam’s eyes searched mine. “Paul, you’re the cleverest man I know. That’s part of the reason I... like you. You’ll work it out.”

Why did she pause before saying “like you?” Was she going to say—

“But the human mind is weird, Paul,” she continued before I could even begin to contemplate her hesitation any further. “Maybe there’s another explanation to all of this. Memory is fallible—we forget things, misremember.”

“One of the files specifically mentioned Elysium.” I reached across the table, taking her hand, deciding to leave it there. I didn’t want to have to explain that the notes told me I had an ex-wife. “Anyway, you’re right. I’ll work it out. Thanks for being patient with me... and not thinking I’m completely nuts.”

“Oh, I didn’t say that,” she teased, squeezing my fingers. “But your kind of nuts is interesting.”

The tension broken, we finished dinner talking about lighter topics—her latest photoshoot, a movie we both wanted to see, plans for the weekend. By the time we stepped outside into the cool night air, I felt almost normal again.

“Who was first?”

The password question floated through my mind as we walked. I’d tried every name I could think of—was I approaching it wrong?

“You’re doing it again,” Sam said, nudging me with her shoulder. “Disappearing into your head.”

“Sorry.” I stopped walking, turning to face her. The streetlight caught her hair, giving it a golden halo. “You’re beautiful, you know that?”

Her cheeks coloured slightly. “Changing the subject?”

“No. Just stating a fact.”

Something shifted between us, the air suddenly charged. Sam stepped closer, her hand coming up to rest against my chest.

“I’ll tell you a fact,” she murmured. “I like you, Paul. A like you a lot.”

“I like you too.”

I kissed her then, right there on the street. Her lips were soft, yielding, then hungry. Her body pressed against mine, fitting perfectly. When we broke apart, her eyes were dark with desire.

“Your place?” she suggested, her voice husky.

The self-driving cab ride was torturous, filled with sexual tension. I could feel the heat of her where she pressed against me. We couldn’t keep our hands off each other. By the time we reached my apartment, my entire body was aching with anticipation. The door had barely closed behind us when Sam was in my arms again, her mouth hot and demanding against mine.

“Let’s go upstairs,” I managed between kisses.

She nodded, already tugging at my shirt as we stumbled down the hallway. Clothes fell in a trail behind us—my jacket, her dress, my shirt. By the time we reached my bed, she wore only black lace underwear, her skin glowing in the blue neon light filtering through the blinds.

“You’re sure?” I asked, my hands poised to undress her.

In answer, she unhooked her bra, not waiting for me, letting it fall away. Her breasts were perfect—full and firm, nipples dark and round, hardening under my gaze.

“Very sure,” she whispered, pulling me down onto the bed.

As my mouth found her breast, Sam gasped, arching beneath me. Her hands threaded through my hair, holding me against her. I lost myself in the taste of her flesh, the soft sounds she made when I moved lower, tracing patterns on her stomach with my tongue.

“Paul,” she moaned as my fingers slipped beneath the lace of her underwear, finding her already wet and ready. “Oh, fuck. Yes.”

Her pussy was smooth, soft, waxed hairless. I stroked her slit slowly, learning what made her breath catch, what made her hips rise to meet my touch. When I slid a finger inside, she cried out, her body tightening around me.

“Go down on me,” she demanded, her voice breaking with need. “I’m so fucking horny.”

I slid her underwear down her legs, tossing it aside before settling between her thighs. The first taste of her pussy sent electricity through my veins. She was sweet and tangy, perfect. As my tongue circled her clit, her fingers tightened in my hair, guiding me.

“Right there,” she gasped. “God, yes.”

I added another finger, curling inside her as I sucked gently. Her thighs trembled on either side of my head.

“Paul, I’m going to—“

She came against my mouth, her body shuddering beautifully. I kept going, gentler now, bringing her down slowly until she tugged me upward.

“Come here,” she whispered, pulling me into a deep kiss. Her hand slid between us, finding me hard and straining against my boxers. “I want you inside me.”

I kicked off my shorts and reached for the condom in my nightstand, but she stopped me.

“I’m on the pill,” she said, her eyes meeting mine. “I want to feel you. Just fuck me.”

The intimacy of the moment hit me hard. As I positioned myself between her legs, something about the way she looked up at me—lips parted, eyes trusting—triggered something deep inside me, a connection I couldn’t quite place but felt intensely.

I pushed inside her slowly, watching her face as she took me in, inch by inch.

“Oh god,” she moaned, wrapping her legs around my waist. “That feels so fucking good.”

I began to move, finding a rhythm that made her gasp with each thrust. Her pussy was slick, wet and tight. Her nails dug into my back, urging me deeper.

“Harder,” she demanded, meeting me thrust for thrust. “I need you harder.”

I obliged, driving into her with increasing force. The headboard knocked against the wall as we moved together, lost in each other. Her body was perfect—her tight pussy gripping me, her full breasts bouncing with each impact. I bent to take a nipple in my mouth, sucking hard, and she cried out my name.

“Paul... I’m close,” she gasped, her inner muscles beginning to flutter around me. “I’m going to cum again. Don’t stop.”

Nothing could have made me stop. I reached between us, finding her swollen clit with my thumb, circling it in time with my thrusts.

She came spectacularly, her back arching off the bed, inner walls clamping down around me. The sight and the feeling of her pleasure pushed me over the edge, and I followed her into oblivion, burying myself deep as I pulsed inside her, filling her with cum.

For a moment, we lay tangled together, breathless and sweaty. Then, Sam smiled up at me, tucking a strand of dark hair behind my ear in a gesture that seemed hauntingly familiar.

“Finally,” she whispered, tracing my jawline with her finger. “I was starting to think you were avoiding this.”

“You were the one stalling.” I pointed out, pulling her closer, savouring the warmth of her body against mine. “Was it worth the wait?”

“Definitely.” Her laugh vibrated against my chest. “Though I wouldn’t have minded if it happened a few weeks ago. I just wasn’t quite ready.”

“I get that.” I kissed the top of her head, breathing in the scent of her shampoo—something lemony and subtle. “It’s been a long time coming, I guess.”

“Too long.” She shifted, propping herself up on one elbow to look at me. “You were a surprisingly good lover for someone who was acting so distracted earlier.”

“I aim to please.”

“You succeeded.” Her fingers traced lazy patterns across my chest. “So, is that all that’s bothering you? This folder thing? Now we’ve finally done the deed, I guess we’re an item now. So, you can talk to me, you know?”

“It’s just the folder, I promise. ‘Cheat Codes’, it’s called.” I hesitated, weighing how much to tell her. “I’ve been trying to solve the latest password hint. It’s been driving me crazy.”

“What kind of hint?” Her interest seemed genuine.

“It’s a puzzle. A simple question. ‘Who was first?’ I’ve tried every name I can think of, but nothing works.”

Sam’s brow furrowed thoughtfully. “First what? First lover? First friend?”

“That’s the thing. I’m not sure.”

She was quiet for a moment, her fingers still tracing patterns on my skin. “Without any context... I don’t know. Maybe it’s not asking for a specific person. Maybe it’s more... conceptual.” She smiled suddenly. “Like Adam. You know, the first man?”

The suggestion hit me with such force I almost sat up. Adam. The biblical first man. Could it really be that simple?

“That’s... actually brilliant,” I said, trying to keep my voice casual.

“I have my moments.” She yawned, snuggling closer. “God, I’m suddenly exhausted.”

I kissed her forehead. “Stay the night if you’d like? It’s the weekend.”

“Really?” Her smile was sleepy but radiant. “I’d like that.”

Within minutes, her breathing had deepened, her body relaxing completely against mine. I lay still, counting the seconds, making sure she was truly asleep before carefully extracting myself from her embrace.

She murmured something incoherent but didn’t wake as I slipped from the bed and pulled on my boxers. The floor was cold beneath my feet as I padded to the living room where my laptop waited.

The password prompt glowed in the darkness, the cursor blinking like a patient adversary.

“Who was first?”

My fingers hovered over the keyboard. Could it really be so obvious? I typed slowly, deliberately:

ADAM

The screen flickered. A new window opened.

Inside was a folder and two new files.

JOURNAL_ENTRY_34.doc and another READ_ME.txt file.

Journal entry? That was too interesting not to read first. I double-clicked it and stared at a document dated June 1, 2029:

“First time with Adam tonight. At least, the first time with Paul there. He watched from the chair in the corner. He didn’t touch me, didn’t touch himself, just watched, never took his eyes from us. Adam was as good as ever—he fucked me good, made me orgasm twice but was respectful of Paul’s boundaries too. When he left, Paul reclaimed me with a passion I haven’t felt in years. Afterward, he held me and thanked me. THANKED ME. For fucking another man while he watched. For letting another man cum inside me.

I’m still processing what this means for us. For me. I’ve always enjoyed fucking other guys. I’m a terrible person, I know. But I am what I am. I like sex. Exciting sex. But tonight... with Paul watching me get fucked... the rush was unlike anything I’ve experienced. I want more. And I think Paul does too.

Next steps: Discuss going further. Maybe Paul doesn’t just watch next time?

-C”

A complicated blend of emotions seared through me. Was this real? If it was... I didn’t know what to think.

I stared at the screen, my fingers trembling over the keyboard, mouse pointer hovering over the ReadMe file. No, I wasn’t going to open it yet. I had enough to think about. I didn’t want to lose even more sleep trying to figure out the next puzzle or whatever else awaited me in there.

I turned off the laptop and went back to bed, sliding under the covers, enjoying the feeling of Sam’s warm nakedness as she cuddled up against me, sighing contentedly. I had no idea what tomorrow was going to hold,

but right now, I needed to focus on the woman by my side, here in the present, not the one that had vanished from my past.

Chapter Five

Light flooded the bedroom as Sam yanked the curtains open, bathing everything in the harsh glow of morning. I groaned, throwing an arm over my eyes.

“Rise and shine,” she announced, crawling back onto the bed and straddling me. Her hair fell forward, tickling my chest as she leaned down to kiss me. “You sleep like the dead, you know that?”

“What time is it?” I mumbled, squinting up at her. She’d pulled on one of my T-shirts, the fabric hanging loose around her curves, reminding me of last night’s activities.

“Almost nine.” She grinned, looking unfairly gorgeous for this time in the morning. “I found real coffee beans in your freezer. Didn’t take you for a coffee snob.”

“There’s a lot you don’t know about me,” I said, then winced at how true that statement was.

“Hmm.” She studied me with those perceptive hazel eyes. “The same can be said about me. Like the fact I’m a puzzle genius.”

My mental fog cleared instantly. “What?”

“The password thing you mentioned at dinner.” She absently traced patterns on my chest. “You need to try ‘Adam’? You know, since the clue was ‘Who was first?’ Adam was literally the first man.”

I stared at her, my heart suddenly pounding. I’d tried it last night while she slept – and it had worked. Claire’s first journal entry about her

experience with Adam had been waiting for me, explicit in ways that had left me both aroused and disturbed. But I couldn't tell Sam that.

"I... haven't tried it yet," I lied, hating myself for it.

"Well, you should. It's brilliant, if I do say so myself." She looked absurdly pleased with herself.

"I will. Later." I pulled her down for a kiss, desperate to change the subject. "Right now, I'm more interested in breakfast. Or maybe just you."

She laughed against my mouth. "Smooth transition."

"I try." I rolled us over, pinning her beneath me, ignoring the part of my brain screaming about the lies already piling up between us.

Sam wound her arms around my neck. "I like this side of you. Assertive. Naughty."

As I kissed her neck, a sudden thought struck me. My parents. They would know if I'd been married. The idea hit me with such clarity that I pulled back, staring down at Sam's confused face.

"What?" she asked, her smile fading. "Did I say something wrong?"

"No," I said quickly. "I just remembered. I was going to visit my mom in D.C. this weekend."

"Your mom lives in D.C.?" Sam propped herself up on her elbows. "You've never mentioned her before."

"Born and raised there," I said, realising I'd never told her much about my past at all. "I don't see her often. Not since Dad died."

Her expression softened. "I'm sorry about your dad."

"It's been a few years," I said, the words feeling rehearsed though I couldn't remember ever saying them before. "But I should visit more often. Mom's alone there now."

"You should definitely go," Sam agreed, reaching up to touch my face. "Family's important."

"Come with me," I said impulsively, then immediately wondered if I'd made a mistake. Having Sam along would complicate things, make it harder to ask the questions I needed to.

"I'd love to meet your mom," she said, her eyes brightening. "That's... that's a big step, Paul."

"Is it? I guess it is."

She grinned, wrapping her arms around my neck. "Are you asking me to officially be your girlfriend, Paul Lacuna?"

“Maybe I am.” I kissed her softly, pushing down the image of Claire that tried to surface in my mind.

“I’d love to,” she said, then her smile faltered. “But I can’t this weekend. I have a massive project due Monday, and I have a queue of photos to edit.”

Relief washed through me, followed immediately by guilt. “Next time,” I promised. “And maybe you can introduce me to your family, too.”

“My dad would love you,” she said, running her fingers through my hair. “Mom’s in Europe with husband number three, but Dad’s just across the river in New Jersey.”

The domesticity of the conversation made my chest tighten. Here I was, planning family introductions while sitting on a secret that could destroy whatever was building between us. A wife I couldn’t remember. A life I’d chosen to forget.

After a lazy breakfast and a lingering goodbye at my door, Sam finally left for her apartment, promising to call me that evening. The moment she was gone, I retrieved my laptop from under the couch and opened it. Claire’s journal entry still displayed on the screen.

I read it again, feeling like a voyeur in my own past life. Claire describing how she’d slept with Adam while I watched from a chair in the corner. How I’d reclaimed her afterward with a passion she hadn’t felt in years. How I’d thanked her for fucking another man.

What kind of person had I been?

I packed quickly, tossing clothes into a duffel bag and carefully stowing my laptop. The drive to D.C. would take a few hours, plenty of time to dig deeper into this mystery.

My car greeted me with its usual chime as I approached. “Good morning, Paul. Where would you like to go today?”

“Hello, Optimus. Mom’s house, please,” I replied, using the comical name I’d given the A.I. and tossing my bag onto the passenger seat. “D.C.”

“Setting course for Elizabeth Lacuna’s residence, Washington D.C.,” Optimus confirmed. “Estimated arrival time: 2:45 PM.”

As the car navigated out of the parking garage and merged onto the highway, I opened my laptop again. But instead of returning to Claire’s journal and the file I still hadn’t opened, I opened a browser and typed: “Elysium memory technology.”

The search results were extensive. Elysium Technologies, founded eight years ago by a consortium of tech entrepreneurs and neuroscientists, had

revolutionised the concept of experiential sharing. Their headquarters dominated a gleaming skyscraper in midtown Manhattan, all glass and chrome with their distinctive logo—a stylized red “e” just like the one on the photograph.

Their flagship product, Skin Deep, worked through a rice-grain-sized implant placed at the base of the skull, near the brain stem. Users then wore what they called a “NeuroLink Crown” to either record their own experiences or download others’. The technology had exploded in popularity among the ultra-wealthy, who could afford to purchase rare or exclusive experiences—scuba diving in the Great Barrier Reef, driving race cars, being a rock star on stage at a major concert.

“Experience without consequence,” their slogan proclaimed in sleek, modern font. “Live beyond your limits.”

The technology seemed simultaneously fascinating and disturbing. I scrolled through pages of articles about Elysium’s meteoric rise, finding nothing about memory removal or erasure. Their public face was all about addition, not subtraction—adding experiences, not taking them away.

"Elysium's Skin Deep: The Future of Experience Sharing?"

Published in TechToday – August 14, 2032

By Rachel Henshaw, Senior Technology Correspondent

In just eight years, Elysium Technologies has transformed from a bold startup into a multi-billion-dollar powerhouse, reshaping how society interacts with memories and experiences. At the heart of their meteoric rise is Skin Deep, an advanced neuro-implant that allows users to record, relive, and purchase the experiences of others.

Once a luxury novelty for the ultra-rich, Skin Deep has expanded its reach, with high-end subscription plans offering everything from extreme sports simulations to celebrity encounters. With the simple application of a NeuroLink Crown, users can experience the thrill of skydiving, the rush of a championship fight, or the intimacy of a passionate romance—all without ever leaving their homes.

"Experience without consequence," boasts the company's official tagline. And investors seem to agree—the company's stock price has nearly tripled in the last 24 months.

However, concerns about ethical implications linger. Critics argue that Elysium is blurring the lines between experience and reality, while regulators continue to debate whether the sale of intimate or dangerous memories should be more strictly controlled.

For now, the demand for Skin Deep shows no signs of slowing down. The question remains—how far is too far when living beyond your limits?

But there, buried in a financial report from last year, was some controversy. First off, a brief mention of a product called “The Formula.” According to the report, Elysium had invested heavily in developing this chemical compound, designed to “enhance personal charisma and physical attractiveness through targeted neurochemical optimization.” In simpler terms: a drug to make you sexier.

The project had hit a significant setback, though details were sparse. Only that it had been “scaled back for reformulation” and would undergo “a new

testing phase with enhanced safety protocols.”

The more interesting part suggested that Skin Deep was being used for other, less moralistic means. Despite being banned on the official vendor sites, sexual encounters were being bought and sold through black market channels.

experiential data. The chip interfaces with Elysium's proprietary neurolink crown, allowing users to upload, download, and share recorded experiences.

On paper, it's a marvel of engineering. In reality, it may not be as secure as Elysium claims.

Unauthorized Access & 'Experience Hacking'

Despite Elysium's insistence that Hard Core is encrypted and secure, multiple whistleblowers have suggested that third parties have found ways to access stored experiences—sometimes without the user's knowledge.

A recent report from cyber-defense firm Black Umbra found that, in certain conditions, unauthorized third parties could tap into Hard Core transmissions, allowing them to view, copy, or even alter recorded memories.

Even more disturbing? Cases of stolen experiences being resold on the black market.

The Black Market for Memories

While Elysium publicly condemns any illicit use of its technology, evidence suggests that Skin Deep has already given rise to a hidden trade in stolen experiences.

An investigation by *The Intercept* revealed that on underground exchange sites, users can purchase illicit recordings of real experiences—often without the original recorder's consent. These include:

- High-adrenaline moments (combat missions, extreme sports, classified government encounters).
- Private confessions and business dealings.
- Sexual experiences—including some where the original participant never consented to sharing.

Regulators have expressed concern that Skin Deep has created a new form of digital exploitation and that Elysium is turning a blind eye to unauthorized trading.

Elysium's Response

This was more interesting to me, but when I got to the end of the article, there was still no mention of memory wiping technology.

I leaned back against the headrest, watching the scenery blur past as my car navigated the highway. What connected Elysium's memory-sharing technology and Claire's journal entries? If they had developed some kind of memory removal procedure, they were keeping it very quiet.

The navigation system chimed softly as the car merged onto the highway, heading south toward D.C. “Route optimized for traffic conditions,” Optimus announced. “Estimated arrival at Elizabeth Lacuna's residence: 2:45 PM.”

I thanked the AI and settled back in my seat, watching the cityscape gradually give way to suburbs. Once traffic thinned, I pulled out my laptop. With Sam safely back at her apartment, I could finally explore what I'd unlocked last night.

The folder waited on my desktop, no longer locked behind the ADAM password. Inside was the journal file, another folder titled MY_SINS, encrypted with another password. A single document was accessible—README.txt. My pulse quickened as I double-clicked it.

“Paul,

If you’re reading this, you’ve found the journal entry about Adam. If you haven’t read it yet. Read that first, then come back to this letter.

If you have read it, then you’ve seen the beginning of our journey together—how we took those first tentative steps into a world neither of us fully understood.

I remember that night so vividly. The nervousness in your eyes as you watched from that chair. The way you reclaimed me afterward with such intensity. We thought we were in control then. We believed we could contain what we’d unleashed.

We were wrong.

You’ve seen the video. You’ve read my words. You know where our marriage led us—to places both exhilarating and dangerous. I won’t apologize for the pleasure we found, but I can’t ignore how things spiraled beyond what either of us intended.

If you want to know more—if you’re ready to remember everything—use this code to unlock the next folder:

TRUE LADY

5736 4128

It’s your choice whether to continue down this path. Part of me hopes you’ll stop here, close this file, and move forward with your life. But another part of me—the selfish part—wants you to remember us.

When you agreed to Fresh Start, you wanted every trace of our life together erased. I respected that choice, but couldn’t bear the thought of our story disappearing forever. So I left these breadcrumbs, hidden where only you might someday find them.

Perhaps one day, when enough time has passed, you’ll look at what we did differently. Maybe you’ll even forgive us both.

I miss you, even though by now, if you’re reading this, you’ve forgotten me entirely.

Forever yours,
Claire.”

I stared at the words until they blurred, my throat tight. Fresh Start. The name struck a chord deep within me, though I couldn't place why. Was that Elysium's memory-erasing technology?

My fingers traced the screen where Claire's name appeared. My wife. The woman I'd chosen to forget.

"TRUE LADY 5736 4128." I studied the strange code, trying to make sense of it. Was it another password? A location? Coordinates?

I tried entering it directly as the password to the MY_SINS folder, but it didn't work.

TRUE LADY. And then eight numbers. It made no sense to me at all. The car hummed beneath me as I stared at the puzzle, frustration building. What was I missing?

I pondered over it for a little while. True lady... Honest woman? I punched it in, more in hope than expectation but it also wasn't right. Loyal wife? Nope. What about the numbers? I stared at it for nearly an hour, testing different combinations, searching for patterns. Nothing worked. Whatever Claire had intended with this clue, it remained just beyond my grasp.

Finally, I closed the laptop in frustration, watching the landscape roll by. Somewhere in my forgotten past was the key to understanding this puzzle—and understanding who I had been. Who we had been together.

One thing was clear: Claire and I had ventured into wife-sharing, with her sleeping with other men while I watched. The thought should have disgusted me, but instead, it awakened something hot and primal in my core. A part of me I didn't recognize—or didn't want to recognize.

As I pulled into my mother's driveway, her modest colonial-style house looked exactly as it always had—white trim freshly painted, flower beds immaculately maintained, the old-fashioned brass knocker polished to a shine. Mom had always been meticulous about appearances.

She must have seen me arrive because the door slid open before I even reached the porch. Elizabeth Lacuna stood there, her salt-and-pepper hair styled in the same practical bob she'd worn for decades, wearing what she called her "good jeans" and a cardigan that brought out the blue in her eyes—my eyes.

"Paul!" She pulled me into a hug that smelled of cinnamon and that lavender perfume she'd worn since I was a kid. "It's been too long."

"Hey, Mom," I said, returning her embrace. "Sorry, it's been a while."

“Three months is more than ‘a while,’ young man.” She stepped back, studying my face with the intensity only mothers can achieve. “You look tired. Are you sleeping enough?”

“Work’s been busy,” I said, following her inside. The house smelled like home—furniture polish, old books, and whatever she’d been baking. “But we just landed a huge contract, so it’s worth it.”

“The coffee’s fresh,” she said, leading me to the kitchen. “And I’ve got those almond cookies you like.”

The kitchen, like everything else, was unchanged—yellow walls, white cabinets, the collection of owl figurines perched above the sink. I settled at the breakfast nook while Mom poured coffee into the mug she kept just for me, the faded NASA one with a chip on the handle.

“So,” she said, placing cookies on a plate between us, “tell me everything. How’s New York? The job? Any special someone?”

I sipped my coffee, gathering my thoughts. “New York’s good. Busy. The job’s better—we landed the Cerulean Hotels security contract. It’s huge for the company. Harry and I have been working on it for months.”

“Oh! How is Harry?” Her face brightened. “Such a nice young man.”

“He’s doing great. He’s seeing someone now—Beth.” I took a cookie, the familiar taste bringing back Sunday afternoons from my childhood. “And I’m, um, seeing someone too. Her name’s Sam.”

Mom’s eyes lit up. “Tell me about her! What does she do? Is it serious?”

“She’s a photographer. Works for magazines and does gallery shows sometimes. And yeah, I guess it’s getting there. She wanted to come this weekend but had a deadline to meet. Photo editing.”

“Next time, you bring her,” Mom insisted, already planning. “I’ll make my pot roast.”

“Speaking of food,” I said, noting the familiar smell wafting from the oven, “is that lasagna?”

“Your favourite,” she confirmed. “With extra cheese, just how you like it. It’ll be ready in about twenty minutes.”

We chatted through another cup of coffee, Mom filling me in on neighborhood gossip and her book club drama. I let the familiar rhythm of her voice wash over me, almost forgetting why I’d really come. Almost.

“Mom,” I finally said during a lull in conversation, “can I ask you something weird?”

She looked up from refilling her mug. “Of course, honey. What is it?”

“Was I ever married?”

The mug froze halfway to her lips. Something flickered across her face—shock, then something like fear, quickly masked. “What kind of question is that?” She tried to laugh, but it sounded hollow. “Don’t you think you’d remember something like marriage?”

“Just answer the question, Mom. Please.”

She set the mug down carefully. “No, Paul. You’ve never been married.”

The lie hung between us, so obvious it might as well have been printed in neon above her head. Mom had never been able to lie to me successfully—her left eye always twitched slightly. It was twitching now.

“You’re not telling me the truth,” I said quietly.

“Paul, this is ridiculous. I think I’d know if my only son had been married.” Her voice rose defensively. “Where is this coming from?”

I pulled out my phone and showed her a still from that I’d saved from the video—close up on the woman’s face so as not to reveal too much. “Do you know her, Mom? Her name is Claire. I’ve been finding files on my computer, messages she left for me.”

Mom’s face drained of colour. “Put that away,” she whispered. “I can’t... I’m not supposed to...”

“Not supposed to what?” I pressed. “Tell me the truth? Tell me about my own life?”

“It’s complicated.” She stood abruptly, moving to check the oven—an obvious diversion.

“Complicated how?” I followed her, no longer willing to back down. “Was I married to her or not?”

“I signed papers.” Her voice trembled. “A contract. I’m not allowed to discuss any of this with you. They were very clear about that.”

“Who’s ‘they’? Mom, what’s going on?”

“I can’t tell you!” Tears welled in her eyes. “Please, Paul. Don’t ask me these questions. I could get in trouble.”

“Trouble with who?” My frustration was mounting. “This is my life we’re talking about!”

“I know. I’m sorry. I... need some time,” she said, wiping her eyes. “Time to think about this. Please, can we just have dinner and talk about it later?”

“No, Mom. I need answers now. Someone has erased parts of my memory, and you clearly know something about it.”

She turned away, her shoulders shaking. “I’m sorry. I can’t help you right now.”

The distance between us felt vast suddenly, filled with secrets I couldn’t pierce. “Fine,” I said, grabbing my jacket. “I’ll go.”

“Paul, wait—the lasagna—“

“I’m not hungry anymore.” I headed for the door, pausing to look back at her. “Call me when you’re ready to tell me—your only child—the truth.”

I stormed out to my car, the remote control gripped so tightly it bit into my palm. Through the window, I could see my mother already on the phone, her face drawn with worry as she spoke urgently to someone.

Who was she calling? Who had she signed papers with?

It was too late to drive back to New York now; my anger and the mental exhaustion from the drive had left me in no condition for the return trip. I needed a place to stay, and suddenly, an idea struck me.

“Optimus, find me the nearest Cerulean Hotel and book a room,” I instructed the vehicle’s AI.

“Searching for Cerulean Hotel locations,” it responded smoothly. “Found: Cerulean Georgetown, 2.7 miles from current location. Shall I book a standard room?”

“Yes,” I confirmed, pressing my thumb to the biometric scanner to start the engine. “And set course.”

The drive to the hotel took less than fifteen minutes through the familiar streets of my hometown. As the car navigated the evening traffic, I tried to relax but couldn’t. The fact that my mother was lying, that she’d admitted to lying, all but confirmed that Claire existed and her story to be true.

But I also couldn’t relax because I’d noticed something odd on the car’s rearview monitor—a dark sedan had been maintaining the same distance behind me for several turns.

I told the car to make a sudden left where it should have gone right, and the sedan followed—definitely not coincidence. I told it to continue to the hotel but take the long way around, and it did, and the strange vehicle behind stayed with us all the way.

The Cerulean Georgetown’s illuminated sign soon appeared ahead, the building’s glass façade gleaming blue against the darkening sky. I pulled into the circular driveway and stopped abruptly, watching as the sedan slowed nearby.

Instead of pulling in, I got out of my car and walked directly toward the sedan. The driver must have panicked at my approach because the vehicle suddenly accelerated, tires squealing as it spun around and pulled away from the hotel and disappeared into the traffic on the main road where we'd come in.

I stood there in the driveway, heart pounding. I hadn't seen the driver's face, but their reaction confirmed what I already suspected.

Someone was following me. Someone who didn't want to be identified.

And somehow, I doubted it was a coincidence that they'd appeared right after my mother's phone call.

Chapter Six

I pulled my luggage from the trunk, instructing my car to park itself in the hotel's automated garage. As I approached the entrance, I still couldn't shake the anxiety that someone had been following me. The mysterious sedan that had followed me from my mother's house had disappeared into traffic, but the uneasiness lingered.

The lobby was as luxurious as I expected it to be—polished marble floors, expensive-looking fake trees in recessed alcoves, and a ceiling installation of floating blue glass orbs that mimicked the movement of water. A subtle fragrance of sandalwood and citrus perfumed the air, the Cerulean's signature scent.

At the reception desk, a woman greeted me with a well-trained smile. She was striking in the way that high-end hotel staff often are—beautiful if over made-up, with pale blonde hair pulled into an immaculate bun, revealing diamond earrings that caught the blue light. Her name tag read 'Cassandra,' and she wore the hotel's uniform—a tailored navy dress with subtle blue piping—like it had been designed specifically for her slender frame.

"Welcome to the Cerulean Georgetown," she said, her voice melodic and polished. "How may I assist you this evening?"

"I need a room for the night," I replied, placing my credit chip on the polished counter. "Just one night."

Her manicured fingers danced across the touchscreen. "We have a Deluxe King available on the twelfth floor, with a view of the Potomac. Would that suit you, Mr...?"

“Lacuna. Paul Lacuna. And yes, that’s fine.”

As she processed my information, a sudden impulse seized me. I pulled out my phone and brought up the photo of the hotel room where she’d prepared to meet her lover.

“Actually, I have an unusual request,” I said, sliding my phone toward her. “This was taken in one of your hotels. I was wondering if you could tell me which hotel. It might even be this one. If so, would you know what room?”

Cassandra’s perfectly shaped eyebrows rose slightly as she glanced at the image. Her professional manner remained intact, but a coolness entered her gaze.

“I’m afraid I can’t identify specific rooms from photographs, sir,” she replied, sliding the phone back toward me. “And even if I could, Cerulean Hotels has strict privacy policies.”

“What about the woman?” I persisted, switching to the video still, zooming in on Claire’s face. “Have you ever seen her?”

The receptionist’s smile tightened. “Mr. Lacuna, we value all our guests’ privacy. I cannot and will not discuss other patrons or their activities.” She straightened, her posture becoming more formal. “If you’re attempting to locate someone staying at our hotel, I suggest contacting them directly.”

Heat crept up my neck. “I’m sorry. It’s not what it sounds like. She’s my... an old friend. I thought she might be staying here.”

“I understand,” Cassandra replied, though her tone suggested otherwise. “Will you still be wanting the Deluxe King on twelve?”

I nodded, embarrassed. “Yes, thank you.”

She completed the check-in process with efficient professionalism, although the warmth had vanished from her interactions.

“That’s booked for you. I’ve sent the door key to your credit chip. Elevators are to your right. Room service is available 24 hours. Enjoy your stay at the Cerulean, Mr. Lacuna.”

In my room—1213—I examined the space closely. The decor matched the lobby’s aesthetic: classic luxury in shades of blue and cream. A king-sized bed dominated the space, and the floor-to-ceiling windows offered a spectacular view of the Potomac River, now a ribbon of black studded with the reflected lights of Georgetown.

I scrutinized every detail, comparing it to Claire’s video. It was very similar in style and layout, but impossible to tell if it was this specific hotel

or not. No distinctive features stood out.

My stomach growled, reminding me I'd skipped dinner with my mother. I picked up the room service menu and ordered lasagna, remembering too late that it was the dish she'd been preparing. The thought of her making that urgent phone call after I left made me uneasy again. Who had she called? What wasn't she telling me?

Fifteen minutes later, a knock announced my dinner's arrival. I opened the door to find a man in his fifties with salt-and-pepper hair and intelligent eyes behind wire-rimmed glasses. He wore the hotel's uniform, though something about his bearing suggested it wasn't his usual attire. He looked like someone who'd lost a high-powered job and had resigned himself to a hotel portering job out of desperation.

"Room service," he announced, wheeling in the cart efficiently. His voice carried a slight accent I couldn't place—not quite British, not quite European. "Lasagna, garlic bread, and sparkling water."

As he arranged the place setting on the small dining table by the window, I noticed his hands—steady, methodical, with a small scar across the right knuckles. There was something deliberate about his movements, a precision that seemed at odds with routine hotel service. What job had he done before this? I almost felt sorry for the guy, but such was the economy these days. There were plenty of highly trained people doing dumb jobs. A.I. had a lot to account for.

"Beautiful evening," he commented, glancing toward the river view. "First time at the Cerulean, Mr. Lacuna?"

The use of my name wasn't unusual—he would have seen it on the order—but something in his tone caught my attention. Before I could respond, he continued.

"Enjoy your meal, sir. If you need anything else, just call down." He smiled politely and left before I could bother him further. I couldn't blame him. Hotel portering must be a boring job.

The lasagna was good but nowhere near my mother's. As I ate, I pulled out my laptop and opened Claire's hidden folder, staring at the clue again.

TRUE LADY

5736 4128

I had an idea. FALSE MAN. I tried the opposites of the words, followed by the reverse of the numbers.

Incorrect.

I tried a few more theories. In code, true equalled one. ONE WOMAN. Nope. I went through a couple of other ideas, but nothing worked.

Feeling defeated and frustrated, I pulled out my phone and called Sam. She answered on the second ring, her voice warm.

“Hey! How’s your mom?”

“Complicated,” I replied, not ready to explain that particular mess. “Listen, I need your help with something.”

“Sure, what’s up?” Sam asked, her voice slightly muffled. I heard rustling in the background, followed by a soft, “Give me a minute.” A few footsteps later, after another brief pause, Sam returned, sounding slightly out of breath. “Okay, I’m ready. What’s this puzzle you need help with?”

I recited the clue to her. “TRUE LADY, then on the next line, 5736 4128.”

“Got it,” Sam replied. “What have you tried so far?”

I explained my attempts, feeling increasingly foolish as I listed them out. Sam hummed thoughtfully.

“Hold on a second, let me grab a pen and paper.” Again, the line went quiet for a moment. “Okay, say that again.”

I repeated the words and the numbers, and in the quiet that followed, I could almost hear her brain whirring.

“Have you considered...?” she started, then paused. “The numbers could be telling you how to rearrange the letters in ‘TRUE LADY.’ Try putting them in that order.”

“What do you mean?”

“The eight numbers have a gap in the middle; that’s what caught my eye,” she explained patiently. “That makes me think the first four numbers correspond to the first word, TRUE. The second set of numbers relates to LADY.”

“Okay, keep going.” I stared at the puzzle, still not understanding where she was going with this.

“So the numbers are telling you the correct sequence of letters. The number 1 is the second number in the second group of four, so it relates to the letter A in LADY. So the first letter is A.”

“Ah.” It was like a light bulb switching on in my brain. I continued with the sequence. 2 was the third letter in the second word, D.

Then a U, then an L... I continued until all 8 letters were in order, according to the number sequence. My eyes widened as the word formed in

my head.

“ADULTERY,” I breathed, a chill running down my spine.

“That’s it?” Sam asked, sounding slightly distracted.

“Wait.” I double-clicked on the encrypted folder and typed it into the password prompt. The folder opened as if by magic.

“Yeah, that’s it. Sam, you’re brilliant,” I said, my mind already racing with implications.

“Glad I could help,” she replied, her voice warm but slightly strained. “Listen, I’ve got to go. But let’s catch up soon, okay? I want to hear all about your trip.”

I hesitated, my eyes fixed on my laptop screen where a list of files filled the screen. Mostly more journal entry files like the last one I’d read.

“Actually,” Sam added, “do you want to meet up tomorrow when you get back from D.C.?”

“I probably won’t be back until late,” I said, distracted by what I was seeing. “Maybe another time?”

As soon as I said that, I felt a sudden pang of guilt. Sam had been nothing but supportive and kind. I hated lying to her. I wasn’t planning on being back late, but I couldn’t tell her that I wanted some time to go through all these files and maybe talk to Harry.

“Listen, Sam,” I said, my voice softening. “I should tell you something. My mom... she wants to meet you. I’ve told her about you.”

“Really?” Sam’s voice brightened, though I detected a slight hesitation beneath her enthusiasm. “That’s... that’s a big deal, Paul.”

“Yeah, it is,” I agreed, smiling despite the complicated emotions swirling inside me. “And there’s something else I need to tell you, but... I think it’s better if we do it in person. Can we meet up Monday or Tuesday?”

“Of course,” Sam replied, sounding both curious and slightly concerned. “Is everything okay?”

“It will be,” I assured her. “I just... I want to do this right. You’re important to me, Sam. Last night was great, and I... I want to see you more.”

I could almost hear her smile through the phone. “You’re important to me too, Paul. Tuesday works for me. We’ll talk then.”

As we said our goodbyes, I felt a mix of relief and apprehension. I knew I needed to tell Sam the truth, but I needed to work out how to tell her I had an ex-wife. Also, right now, I had a more immediate matter to attend to. I

turned back to my laptop and stared at the newly unlocked folder labelled MY_SINS. Inside were several files with cryptic names—journal entries labelled by date, a video file called “First_Time_Adam_Paul.mp4”, an image file simply named “Fishing.jpg”, and a text document titled “READ_ME_FIRST.txt”.

The journal entries intrigued me, their dates spanning several months. The video and photo made my pulse quicken, knowing they likely contained explicit content of Claire with another man. But it was the Read Me file that drew my attention most. Whatever secrets this folder held, that document seemed the logical place to start. Taking a deep breath, I double-clicked to open it, bracing myself for whatever revelations it might contain about my forgotten past with Claire.

“Dear Paul,

If you’re reading this, you’ve unlocked more of our past. I hope you’re ready for the truth, because what follows isn’t easy to admit.

I was unfaithful to you. It started after a terrible argument we had. In my anger and hurt, I slept with a coworker. I never told you, and the guilt ate at me. But instead of confessing, I made another mistake. And another. I cheated on you again and again.

I even started keeping a diary of these encounters. I don’t know why — maybe to process my guilt, maybe because part of me enjoyed the thrill. I hid these entries in a folder on my computer called “Cheat Codes.”

Then you found it. You guessed my password—the name of the restaurant where we had our first date. I expected rage when I found out you knew. Instead, you were aroused. You told me you’d been reading my entries for weeks, getting off to them in secret.

When you finally confronted me, you didn’t want me to stop. You wanted to watch. That’s how we ended up with Adam that night in the hotel room.

Things developed from there. When it all became too much, when it got out of control, and we decided to split, when you decided to go ahead with the memory wipe, you started writing these notes to your future self. I added to it. We thought maybe someday we’d want to remember. But you changed your mind.

You took some of the files from my computer and hid them on yours, encrypting them with passwords I could never crack. I’ve tried everything I know, but they remain locked. Maybe you’ll remember how to access them. That’s up to you now.

I finished these letters alone, hoping that one day you'd find them and start to remember us. There is a way back, Paul, if you want it. But you need to know the safe word sequence. Your personal safe word sequence. Only you know what it is.

If you remember, if you want me back, you have to find me. When you do, say my safe word sequence. I'm telling you what it is right now.

COOK MARK HAND END WORM

I'll be waiting, hoping that somehow, we can find our way back to each other.

Always,
Claire."

I stared at the screen, my mind reeling from the revelations. The story of our relationship—from her initial infidelity to our shared exploration of wife-sharing was laid bare. It felt weird and wrong and yet, strangely familiar. A part of me wanted to reject it all as fiction, but the details rang true in a way I couldn't explain.

I moved the mouse pointer to the video file labeled "First_Time_Adam_Paul.mp4". Did I really want to see this? To watch my wife—a woman I couldn't even remember—with another man? But I needed answers, and this might provide them.

Taking a deep breath, I double-clicked the file and pressed play.

The video loaded, revealing a hotel room bathed in soft lighting, similar to the one I was in now. My breath caught in my throat as I saw Claire for the first time in motion. She was stunning—long dark hair, twinkling eyes, a nervous smile on her full lips as she looked directly at the camera.

"Hey baby," she purred, her voice sending an unexpected shiver down my spine. "Are you ready for this?"

The camera angle shifted, and I realized with a start that I must have been the one filming. My own voice, definitely my voice, came from off-screen. "I think so. Are you sure about this, Claire?"

She nodded, biting her lower lip in a way that was both innocent and incredibly sexy. "I'm sure. I want this. I want you to see this."

A knock at the door made Claire jump slightly. She smoothed her hands over her short black dress, then moved to answer it. The camera followed her, revealing a tall, well-built man with sandy blonde hair standing in the doorway.

“Adam,” Claire greeted him, her voice a mix of excitement and nervousness. “We meet again.”

As I watched Claire and Adam begin to kiss passionately, I was surprised by my own reaction. Instead of jealousy or disgust, I felt a growing arousal. My body responded instinctively to the sight even if my mind couldn’t recall the details of our relationship.

Unable to resist, I slipped a hand into my pants, touching myself as the video continued playing. Claire’s dress soon came off, as did her bra and panties, revealing a perfect pair of firm breasts and a smooth, shaved pussy. Within moments, she was on her knees in the bedroom, pulling out his cock, which was long and thick and already standing to attention.

I couldn’t take my eyes from the screen as she took him in her mouth, her eyes looking sideways at me, her lips curving into a teasing smile at the sight of me watching and filming.

Adam’s moans filled the room as Claire sucked him enthusiastically, and I found myself stroking faster, unzipping my jeans, completely engrossed in the erotic scene unfolding before me. As things went further, as she joined him on the bed, straddling him, sliding her married pussy onto his girthy shaft, I kicked my jeans off altogether, jerking off fast and free.

Then she rode Adam, her gorgeous breasts bouncing with each movement. The camera angle shifted, turning, revealing my own face watching from a nearby chair. The expression I wore was one of intense focus and unmistakable arousal.

“Do you like what you see, baby?” Claire purred, looking directly at the camera as I turned it back around. “God, he feels so good inside me. His cock is so fucking big and hard.”

The camera looked down for a moment, to my hand stroking my exposed cock in the hotel room. “You look beautiful, Claire,” my voice said, husky with desire. “Show me how much you’re enjoying him.”

As Claire’s movements became more frantic, her moans growing louder, I found myself mimicking my on-screen counterpart. My hand moved faster, matching the rhythm of Claire’s bouncing hips. The sight of her fucking another man while I watched should have disgusted me, but instead, it drove me crazy.

Adam’s hands gripped Claire’s waist, pulling her down harder onto him. “I’m close,” he grunted.

“Me too,” Claire gasped. She turned to the camera again. “Paul, baby, I’m going to cum on his cock. Is that okay? Do you want to see that?”

My recorded voice responded with enthusiasm. “Yes, do it. Cum for me, Claire. Let me see how you orgasm on a big dick.”

I watched, transfixed, as Claire’s body tensed, her back arching as she cried out in ecstasy. Adam followed soon after, his face contorting with pleasure as he emptied himself inside her.

The intensity of their shared orgasm pushed me over the edge. I came hard, sticky white cum spilling over my hand. For a moment, I was lost in the sensation, my mind blissfully blank.

As the afterglow faded, shame crept in. I had just masturbated to a video of my ex-wife—a woman I couldn’t even remember—having sex with another man. What kind of person was I? What kind of relationship was it that we had?

I cleaned myself up, unable to look at the screen where the video had frozen on a final image of Claire, flushed and satisfied, curled up between Adam and my former self.

Tossing the tissues in the bin, I returned to the laptop. The rest of the files in the folder beckoned, promising more revelations, more glimpses into a life I had chosen to forget. But I was suddenly exhausted, both physically and emotionally. Everything I’d learned tonight pressed down on me heavily, like a physical force.

I closed the laptop, deciding the remaining files could wait until morning. As I lay in bed, my mind raced with questions. Why had I agreed to watch Claire with other men? Why had it turned me on so much? And most pressingly—why did it turn me on so much, even now?

I stared at the ceiling, desperately trying to recall any fragment of our life together. The video had been explicit, arousing, but frustratingly devoid of context. How had Claire and I met? Why had I not divorced her when I first found the diary of her cheating? Who was Adam, and how did he figure into all of this? I had hoped that watching it might trigger some buried memory, some flash of recognition, but my mind remained stubbornly blank.

As exhaustion began to overtake me, my thoughts drifted to Harry. My friend often talked in his sleep—could that be a sign that memories weren’t truly gone? Perhaps mine weren’t deleted, just repressed somehow. The idea gave me a glimmer of hope as I finally drifted off. Maybe in my dreams, I would find the answers that eluded me in waking life.

Chapter Seven

I stood under the hot spray of the shower, letting the water cascade over my body as I tried to process everything I'd learned last night and this morning. The video of Claire and Adam played on repeat in my mind, stirring a confusing mix of arousal and discomfort. I'd watched it several times now, each viewing leaving me more conflicted than the last.

As I lathered shampoo into my hair, I recalled the journal entries I'd read earlier. Each one was dated, going back to 2028, some five years ago. One in particular nagged at me: Claire writing about a lover named Jean-Marc. She'd described him as well-endowed, putting my size and skills to shame. She wrote that it had made her see me as less, which in turn made her feel guilty. Was that why we'd started the whole wife-sharing thing? Had I been trying to prove something? After reading that, my interest waned, and I closed the laptop. Even though the degrading comment was made by a woman I no longer knew, it still stung.

The hot water began to run cold, matching my mood. I stepped out of the shower, wrapping a towel around my waist. My reflection in the steamy mirror looked tired, eyes shadowed with the stress of it all.

A knock at the door startled me. Right, the room service I'd ordered before my shower. I quickly dried off and pulled on a robe before answering.

"Good morning, sir," the same man from last night greeted me, wheeling in a covered tray. His eyes held a knowing twinkle. "I trust you had a pleasant night?"

I nodded, grateful for his discretion. “Yes, thank you. I slept well.”

As he set up my breakfast—a simple combination of buttery croissants and fresh, hot coffee—I noticed a small blue light flashing in the wall. Not a camera, I realized, but one of the experience sensors for the software Harry and I were developing. That was odd—the system wasn’t supposed to be operational yet. How did I not notice it last night?

“Excuse me,” I said to the room service attendant. “Do you know anything about these sensors in the rooms?”

He glanced at the blinking light, then shrugged. “They were installed recently, sir. I’m afraid I don’t know much about their purpose.”

He left, and with a sigh, I sat to eat even though I wasn’t particularly hungry. There were too many questions and too many gaps in my memory that I was becoming aware of. I needed to talk to Harry, to tell him about my mom’s reaction and the video confirming my marriage. And Sam... god, Sam. I owed her the truth, even if it meant risking our relationship.

After I’d drunk my fill of coffee and put some food in my stomach, I headed downstairs to check out. The lobby was quieter this morning, with just a few early risers milling about. To my relief, the snotty blonde receptionist from yesterday was nowhere to be seen. Instead, a friendly-looking brunette manned the front desk, her warm smile a stark contrast to yesterday’s cold reception.

“Checking out, Mr. Lacuna?” she asked, her fingers flying over the keyboard.

“Yes, thank you,” I replied, giving her my credit chip to ensure the room key was removed from it.

As she processed my departure, I couldn’t help but glance around, half-expecting to see someone watching me. The experience of being followed last night still bothered me. But the lobby remained stubbornly ordinary, no strangers observing me, no car hanging around near the entrance, waiting for me to leave.

Soon, I was in my self-driving car, merging onto the highway back to NYC. The familiar scenery passed by in a blur as my mind raced with plans and priorities. I deliberately kept my laptop closed, resisting the urge to dive back into Claire’s files and read more of the journal entries. I needed time to process everything without going deeper down that rabbit hole.

My thoughts kept circling back to Sam. The lovemaking on Friday night had been amazing, and I realised that I was missing her, plus the guilt of

keeping secrets from her was eating away at me. She deserved the truth, even if it meant risking our relationship. I'd surprise her by coming home early and lay it all out—ex-wife, memory wipe, everything.

But how would that conversation even start? "Hey Sam, funny story—turns out I was married before and had my memory erased. Want to help me figure out why?" It sounded insane even in my head.

Sam was smart, analytical. Part of me hoped she might be able to help me make sense of it all. But another part feared her reaction. Would she think I was crazy? Or worse, would she be hurt that I'd kept this from her and not shared it earlier?

The thought of potentially losing her made my chest ache. Things had been going so well between us. We clicked in a way I hadn't experienced before—or at least, not that I could remember. The irony of that thought wasn't lost on me.

As the Manhattan skyline came into view, Optimus navigating through the familiar streets towards my apartment, my resolve strengthened. It was time to start facing the truth, whatever consequences it might bring. I just hoped that when all was said and done, I wouldn't find myself alone again, adrift in a life I didn't fully understand.

The car pulled into my building's parking garage, and I sat there for a moment, gathering my courage. I tried calling mom again to see if she'd changed her mind about talking—she'd had time to think about it now—but just like this morning, when I'd tried calling before my shower, there was no answer.

I got out, swinging my overnight bag over my shoulder but when the elevator doors opened, I was surprised to find Haley inside, looking back at me with equal surprise.

"What are you doing here?" I asked her. "You're not due to clean until Tuesday. I paid you on Friday, right?"

Haley tucked a strand of blonde hair behind her ear. "I, um, left my spare set of keys." She pointed to a keyring in her hand. Her house must still use the old fashioned type locks. "I called by to get them and got worried when you weren't home. I was just about to call you."

I nodded, trying to shake an odd feeling, a moment of déjà vu that I couldn't explain. Another memory from the past trying to return to the surface, maybe?

“I went to D.C.” I explained as she put the keys into her pocket. “To see my mom.”

“How was she?” she asked, her brown eyes studying me with what seemed like genuine concern.

“All good,” I replied. Why was she hanging around, blocking me from the elevator?

“Actually, Paul,” she began, her voice hesitant. “While you’re here, I wanted to ask... I’m having some financial troubles. Would it be possible to get a small raise?” Her cheeks flushed with embarrassment. “I wouldn’t ask, but I’m really struggling this month.”

Ah. So that was the real reason she’d come by. It made more sense than her flimsy excuse about the keys.

“Of course,” I said, relieved to have a normal problem to solve. “We can work something out.”

“Thank you,” she said, smiling with genuine relief. “I should get going.”

As she left, hurrying out into the busy street beyond, I found myself watching her movements. There was something about her that kept nagging at the edges of my consciousness, like a word on the tip of my tongue I couldn’t quite recall.

I shrugged the feeling off, heading up to the apartment and quickly changed from the clothes I’d travelled in, into something a bit smarter. It was time to see Sam and tell her everything.

Sam’s apartment was in a renovated brownstone in the West Village. I’d only been here once before, when I’d picked her up for our second date. The memory made me smile—she’d been running late, invited me up while she finished getting ready. Just five minutes in her space had told me so much about her: the organized bookshelves arranged by topic rather than author, the collection of vintage cameras and the array of photographs that she’d taken and framed to decorate the walls.

I parked across the street, rehearsing what I’d say one last time. The afternoon had turned to evening, and the air had grown cooler, so I zipped up my jacket as I approached her building. The lights were on in her ground-floor apartment, warm and inviting against the reddening sky.

I was about to cross the street when movement in her window caught my eye. Sam wasn't alone. Through the partially open curtains, I could see her gesturing animatedly as she talked to someone—a man with broad shoulders and dark hair.

I froze, watching as the man moved closer to her. Even from this distance, I could tell he was handsome in a rugged way, with caramel skin and the confident posture of someone comfortable in their body. He reached for her, and instead of stepping back, Sam allowed him to pull her closer.

I should have looked away. Or I should have crossed the grass outside the apartment, rung her buzzer, and announced my presence. Instead, I found myself stepping deeper into the shadow of a tree near the window, my eyes fixed on the scene unfolding above me.

The man—a Latino guy I'd never seen before—cupped Sam's face in his hands. I couldn't hear their words, but their body language spoke volumes. This was intimate, familiar. A conversation between people who knew each other well.

I watched as he kissed her, his large hands sliding down to her waist. Sam didn't resist. For a moment, she even seemed to respond, her body arching toward his.

My chest tightened painfully. After everything I'd discovered about Claire, about my forgotten past, finding Sam in another man's arms felt like a cruel joke from the universe. Yet I couldn't look away as the stranger's hands moved to the buttons of her blouse, revealing the lacy black bra I'd admired just days earlier.

Something burned inside me—not just jealousy, but a disturbing flicker of arousal. The same feeling I'd experienced watching the video of Claire and Adam. What was wrong with me that I found myself transfixed, heart racing, as another man touched the woman I was falling for?

The parallel wasn't lost on me. Just as I'd watched Claire with Adam in that hotel room, just as I'd seen Harry and Beth, here I was again—the observer, the voyeur, separated from the action this time by a pane of glass. Was this pattern part of who I was? Some fundamental aspect of my sexuality that even memory erasure couldn't remove?

I watched, transfixed, as Sam led the man to her couch. She didn't push him away when he finished unbuttoning her blouse. Instead, she helped, shrugging it off her shoulders and helping him to unclasp her bra, so it fell to floor, revealing those perfect breasts. He kissed her neck as his hands

explored her tits with the confidence of someone who'd done this many times before.

My rational mind screamed at me to leave, to stop watching this intimate violation of my budding relationship. But I couldn't tear my eyes away as she dropped to her knees in front of him, her fingers working at his belt buckle. Within moments, she'd freed him and taken his long, soft cock into her mouth, her head bobbing in a rhythm that suggested this wasn't the first time she'd sucked him.

My stomach twisted into knots. Sam had been two-timing me. All those times she'd been hesitant about getting more serious, those evenings when she'd been "busy with work"—this explained everything. I felt stupid, betrayed, and strangely aroused all at once.

The scene continued for several more minutes until Sam suddenly paused and got up, moving to the window to close the curtains. But as she took hold of them, she glanced through the window and somehow saw me, hiding in the shadows of the tree. Our eyes met for the briefest moment before she jumped back in shock, her hand flying to her mouth. She said something urgent to the man, who turned to follow her gaze. I ducked behind the tree, but it was too late.

I turned and walked quickly toward my car, my heart hammering in my chest. Behind me, I heard the building's door burst open.

"Paul! Paul, wait!" Sam's voice called out, desperate and panicked.

I kept walking, my jaw clenched tight.

"Paul, please!" She caught up to me, grabbing my arm. I looked over my shoulder but didn't stop. Her blouse was hastily rebuttoned, her lipstick smudged. "It's not what it looks like!"

I turned to face her, anger and hurt bubbling up inside me. "Really? Because it looked pretty clear from where I was standing."

"Please, let me explain," she begged, tears forming in her eyes. She took my hand, squeezing it hard. "That's... he's... you have to let me explain."

"Save it, Sam." I pulled away from her grip. "I don't want to hear it."

"Paul, please. I care about you. This isn't—"

"I said save it!" My voice came out harsher than I intended, but I couldn't help it. The image of her on her knees for another man was seared into my brain.

I walked away and climbed into my car, slamming the door. Through the window, I could see Sam standing on the sidewalk, tears streaming down

her face. For a moment, I almost reconsidered. Then I remembered the casual way she'd unbuttoned her blouse for him, how easily she'd dropped to her knees. How she'd so willingly took his cock in her mouth and sucked it.

"Optimus, get us out of here," I instructed the AI. "Take me home."

As the car pulled away, I saw her in my rear view mirror, growing smaller until she disappeared entirely. My mind was a chaotic mess of emotions, but one thought crystallized above the others: I needed to do something—anything—to stop thinking about what I'd just witnessed. I needed an end to this torment. I'd found Elysium's headquarters address online—a sleek skyscraper in Midtown that housed their corporate offices. Maybe seeing the place would trigger something, some memory that could help me make sense of all this. Perhaps there'd be someone there I could talk to. Someone who could begin answering the million questions in my head.

"Optimus, change destination," I instructed my car's AI. "Take me to Elysium Technology Headquarters."

"Changing route," the car responded smoothly. "Taking you to 1157 Sixth Avenue."

As we merged into the early evening traffic, I noticed something in my rear view mirror—a black sedan, three cars back, keeping pace with mine. The same type of car I'd glimpsed yesterday. It couldn't be... could it? My pulse quickened.

"Optimus, can you zoom in on the rear view camera, focusing on that black sedan behind us?"

The dashboard monitor enhanced the rear view, focusing on the vehicle. As the image sharpened, I felt my blood freeze. Behind the wheel sat the salt-and-pepper-haired room service guy from the Cerulean Hotel, his eyes fixed intently on my car.

"Jesus," I whispered. "He followed me from D.C."

Before I could process this, my steering wheel suddenly jerked to the right.

"What the hell?" I grabbed the manual steering wheel, but it was locked in position. The car accelerated, cutting across two lanes of traffic. Horns blared around us.

"Warning: external override initiated," Optimus announced in its calm voice. "Vehicle control compromised."

For a second, the control monitor changed, displaying an ID and a logo but only for the briefest second. I didn't get a chance to read it.



“Disengage override!” I shouted, frantically tapping the emergency manual control button. Nothing happened.

“I apologize, but I cannot comply. External system has priority access.”

“What external system, Optimus? What’s going on?”

My car shot down a side street, tires screeching. On the rear view monitor, I saw the black sedan swerve violently, attempting to follow. The room service guy’s face was contorted with concentration as he navigated through the traffic in pursuit.

“This isn’t Optimus,” The AI replied. “Don’t worry. You are safe.”

Another severe swerve, missing two cars by inches. I didn’t feel safe.

“Who are you?” I demanded of my hijacked AI. “What do you want?”

A new voice came through the speakers—male, with a hint of a Southern accent. “Hello, Paul. Sorry about the dramatic entrance, but we needed to get you away from your tail.”

“We?” I asked, holding onto my seat desperately as the car zigzagged between two trucks.

“Your mother reached out to me. You’re in danger, Paul. Elysium knows you’re trying to remember.”

My car continued its wild journey through Manhattan, weaving through traffic at alarming speeds, running yellow lights, and taking sharp turns down narrow streets. The black sedan stayed doggedly on our tail.

“Hold tight,” the new voice warned. “This might get rough.”

My car suddenly accelerated through an intersection just as the light turned red, then made a hard left into a service alley. The sedan followed, narrowly missing a delivery truck.

“Who is that guy? The one from the hotel?” I asked, gripping my seat as the car swerved again.

“One of Elysium’s watchdogs. They’ve been monitoring you since you started asking questions.”

We burst out of the alley onto the West Side Highway, my car pushing well beyond the speed limit. The Hudson River glittered to our right as we raced downtown.

“I’m going to create a distraction,” the stranger said. “When I do, your car will take a specific route. Our friend won’t be able to follow.”

Near the Chelsea Piers, my car suddenly cut across all lanes, causing a cascade of braking and swerving behind us. As we took the exit, I glimpsed the black sedan caught in the chaos, a delivery truck blocking its path.

“We lost him,” I breathed, watching the sedan disappear from view on the rear monitor.

“For now,” the voice replied. “I’m taking you somewhere we can talk.”

The car wound through the streets of Chelsea before pulling up alongside an old railway access point. The High Line—the elevated rail line turned park—loomed above, but this section hadn’t been renovated like the tourist-friendly parts.

“Get out here,” the new AI instructed. “Take the metal stairs up to the abandoned section of the track. I’ll meet you there.”

“How do I know this isn’t a trap?” I demanded.

“You don’t,” the strange voice admitted. “But your mother trusts me, Paul. I’m the only one who can help you understand what happened to you, Claire, and Harry.”

The car unlocked itself. With my heart pounding, I stepped out into the fading evening light and approached the rusted metal staircase. Each step up felt like I was climbing toward answers—or perhaps toward more danger.

At the top, the abandoned rail line stretched before me, overgrown with weeds and wildflowers. The skeletal structures of old warehouses framed the view, while the gleaming towers of Hudson Yards loomed nearby—the perfect metaphor for my situation: caught between a forgotten past and an uncertain future.

A tall man stood with his back to me, looking out over the Hudson River as it caught the golden light of the setting sun. He turned as I approached, and I recognized him immediately from the video —Adam, the man who fucked my wife while I watched.

“Hello, Paul,” he said, his expression serious. “It’s been a long time.”

Afterword

Hey there, awesome reader!

Holy crap, what a wild journey, huh? I hope you had as much fun diving into Paul's twisted world as I did writing it. But hold onto your hats, 'cause we're just getting started!

In "Hard Core," we're gonna dig even deeper into Elysium's shady memory tech. Paul's gonna uncover some seriously shocking stuff about his past with Claire. And Sam? Let's just say she's got a few surprises up her sleeve too.

Get ready for more steamy scenes, mind-bending twists, and a few "holy shit" moments that'll leave you breathless. We'll push the limits of trust, desire, and identity. It's gonna be one hell of a trip!

Oh, and remember that mysterious "Formula" I mentioned? Keep an eye out for future books diving into "The Formula" and "Skin Deep" - they've got stories of their own to tell!

Thanks for joining me on this crazy adventure. I can't wait to share the next chapter with you all. Until then, keep questioning those memories... you never know what juicy secrets they might be hiding!

See ya in "Hard Core"!

Your partner in crime,

Paul

P.S. Don't forget to leave a review (or a star-rating) if you enjoyed the book. It helps more than you know!



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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 saw the *My Wife* series and the *I Know Who You Did Last Summer* series reach huge success and 2025 brings the return of the Detective Hotwife, a new series of sci-fi hotpast erotica and the climax of the *Holiday Hotwives* books.

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